

ARÊTE

A K–12 Character Formation Program

Complete Scope & Sequence · 130 Lessons · Learning Objectives

Arête (ἀρετή): the Greek concept of the highest expression of one's nature — excellence of character, the fullest actualization of what a human being can be. Aristotle made it the center of his entire ethics. This curriculum makes it the center of twelve years of deliberate formation.

This curriculum asks one question. It asks it 130 times, across thirteen years, at increasing depth. The question is: who are you becoming — and is that who you were meant to be? Every lesson, every learning objective, every formation ground is a different angle on that single question.

THE FORMATION FRAMEWORK

Five Worldview Threads — K to 12

The curriculum is organized around a single philosophical commitment: the human being has a genuine nature, a genuine telos, and a genuine capacity for self-knowledge that is also a capacity for knowing what is ultimately real. This is the philosophical position the curriculum holds — not as religious doctrine requiring assent, but as a worldview worth inhabiting and worth examining. Every lesson is an angle on this position.

Thread 1	The cosmos as disclosive. The natural world is not merely mechanism — it is a reality that points beyond itself. The great wisdom traditions of humanity, from Aristotle to the Islamic philosophers to the perennial philosophy to Whitehead, agree: the cosmos's existence, order, and beauty require an account that goes beyond mechanism. Introduced in Grade 3; fully developed in Grade 9.
Thread 2	The self as a mirror. The interior life has a quality — more or less clear, more or less distorted — that determines the quality of everything that flows from it: perception, desire, relationship, action. Formation is the cultivation of interior clarity. Introduced in Grade 1; returned to at every stage.
Thread 3	Self-knowledge as the path to genuine knowing. The philosophical tradition from Socrates to Avicenna agrees: genuine knowledge of the self is the gateway to genuine knowledge of reality. The inward journey and the journey toward truth are the same journey at different depths. Runs from Grade 3 to Grade 12.
Thread 4	Verified knowledge as the formation goal. The movement from inherited belief to examined, personally owned conviction — from taqlid to tahqiq in the Islamic tradition, from 'knowledge by description' to 'knowledge by acquaintance' in the philosophical tradition. Seed in Grade 5; dominant frame from Grade 8 onward.
Thread 5	The fully realized human being as horizon. The concept of arête — the highest expression of one's nature — is the formation horizon that gives every lesson its ultimate direction. Not an achievement to be declared but a direction to be inhabited across a lifetime.

The Three-Part Learning Objective Framework

Every lesson carries three learning objectives that ensure all three dimensions of formation are addressed:

Conceptual	What the student can name, distinguish, apply, and analyze. The only category directly and unambiguously assessable. Provides the vocabulary through which Reflective and Dispositional work becomes possible.
Reflective	What the lesson creates conditions for the student to encounter in their own interior life. Never assessed on content — only on quality of honest engagement. The private option is structurally non-negotiable.
Dispositional	The orientation shift the lesson contributes to over time. Never assessed at the lesson level — witnessed across years. States the directional movement of the formation arc from its current stage toward its next.

The Five Levels of the Spiral

Level 1 — Wonder (K-2)	The question is lived and felt. It arrives through a leaf, a story, a feeling. No analysis. The teacher's role is to protect and deepen wonder.
Level 2 — Reflection (3-5)	The question becomes reflective. The student steps back and examines experience. Distinctions begin to appear.
Level 3 — Diagnosis (6-8)	The question becomes diagnostic. What is actually happening — in me, in my relationships, in my culture? The formation vocabulary enters fully.
Level 4 — Philosophy (9-11)	The question becomes philosophical. Classical sources engage directly. The student holds genuine complexity.
Level 5 — Synthesis (12)	The question becomes synthetic and personal. The student brings their entire formation arc to bear on a final version of the question that has traveled with them since Kindergarten.

COMPLETE LESSON SCOPE & SEQUENCE — ALL 130 LESSONS

KINDERGARTEN — Age 5–6

Wonder, Safety, and the Gift of Being

The foundational year. Formation here is entirely embedded in experience, story, and the quality of the teacher's presence. Children are in full imitation mode — they absorb moral reality through relationships before conceptual instruction can reach them. Every lesson is structured around a concrete experience, a story, and a brief reflection. The central conviction of the curriculum is already operative here: the self is not a blank slate to be filled but an original nature to be discovered and cultivated. Wonder is the first faculty of the person who will later become genuinely good.

L01 Lesson 1: I Am

Who am I?

Why This Topic	Every serious account of character begins with the question of self. The child who discovers there is a 'me' here — something irreplaceable and intended — stands on different ground from the child who has never encountered this. The seed of genuine self-knowledge is planted in wonder, not analysis.
Content	Students explore their name, their face, their hands, their voice. The teacher conveys: this particular 'you' is unrepeatable. The world did not have to have exactly you — and yet here you are. This is the beginning of the question that the curriculum returns to across twelve years.
Approach & Methods	Story circle, mirror activity, name-meaning exploration, self-portrait drawing. Teacher models genuine delight at each child as a distinct and irreplaceable person.
Teaching Principles	Begin with beauty. The child's first encounter with self-knowledge must be celebratory, not analytical. Wonder before questioning. A child who feels their existence is a gift will approach formation from a completely different posture than one who simply exists.
Formation Ground	Aristotle, Plato, and the great wisdom traditions of humanity agree on a striking point: character formation is not the installation of something foreign but the discovery and cultivation of what is already present. The authentic self is not constructed — it is disclosed. This is the first seed of that insight.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can say their name, describe one thing that makes them
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	unique, and express that they matter.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for the child to feel — not merely understand — that their existence is particular and intended.
Dispositional	Over time, this lesson contributes to moving from unreflective self-existence toward a growing sense of the self as something real, irreplaceable, and worth knowing.

L02 Lesson 2: My Body Is a Gift

Why should I care for myself?

Why This Topic	Embodied gratitude is the foundation of stewardship. The body introduced not as property to use but as something entrusted — worth caring for with attention and respect. This is also the beginning of the concept that we are custodians of what we have been given, not owners.
Content	Care for the body — sleep, eating, movement, cleanliness — introduced as gratitude and love, not hygiene rules. Every organ of the body is a small wonder: the hand that draws, the eye that sees, the heart that beats without being asked.
Approach & Methods	Body-tracing art, gratitude songs, movement games, sensory exploration. Teacher narrates self-care as an act of reverence for something remarkable.
Teaching Principles	Virtue through ritual. Washing, resting, and eating well become formation acts when framed as gratitude rather than compliance. The body as the first book of wonders the child can read.
Formation Ground	Philosophers from Aristotle to the Stoics understood the body not as a prison of the soul but as its instrument. To care for the body well is to honor the gift of existence. The child who learns to wonder at their own hand is beginning to develop the perceptual capacity that will later make them capable of genuine gratitude.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can name one way they care for their body and explain that their body is something remarkable worth looking after.
Reflective	This lesson invites students to notice their own body as something wonderful that was given to them rather than something they simply have.

Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from body-as-tool toward body-as-trust — the beginning of a stewardship orientation.
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L03 Lesson 3: Feelings Are Real

What is happening inside me?

Why This Topic	Emotional literacy is the precondition for empathy, honesty, and the entire interior life. The child who cannot name what is happening inside cannot examine it, regulate it, or offer it genuinely to another person. This lesson opens the door to the interior — the most important territory of the entire curriculum.
Content	Basic emotions named, drawn, and explored through story. The interior life introduced as real and worth attending to. Children learn that feelings arise in them, are informative, and do not have to dictate behavior — there is a space between feeling and action.
Approach & Methods	Picture books, emotion faces, movement theater, calm-down practice. Teacher models naming their own feelings aloud, without shame.
Teaching Principles	Name before managing. The moment a child can say 'I am feeling angry' they have created space between themselves and the feeling. That space is where agency begins — and where genuine character lives.
Formation Ground	Every major tradition of human wisdom — from Aristotle's treatment of the passions to modern developmental psychology — agrees: emotional literacy is not a soft skill. It is the foundational cognitive and moral capacity without which all other formation work is inaccessible. You cannot examine what you cannot name.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can name at least three feelings and describe where in their body they feel them.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to begin noticing their interior life as real and worth attending to.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from acting out interior states to observing and naming them — the beginning of genuine self-knowledge.

L04 Lesson 4: Being Kind

What does kindness feel like?

Why This Topic	The first virtue introduced explicitly. Kindness is concrete, visible, immediately available to a five-year-old, and immediately rewarding — the ideal entry point into the entire architecture of character. The child who has felt the warmth of genuine kindness — given and received — has the experiential foundation for everything that follows.
Content	Kindness as action and attention: noticing others, including the left-out child, using gentle words, physical care. The emphasis is always on choosing kindness — making the interior orientation visible in the exterior act.
Approach & Methods	Role-play scenarios, kindness jar, storytelling. Teacher publicly notices and names kindness when it appears in the classroom.
Teaching Principles	Virtue through noticing. Children learn to see kindness in the world before they are asked to practice it. What is noticed grows. The teacher's attention to genuine kindness is itself a formation act.
Formation Ground	Aristotle held that virtue is first learned by doing — we become kind by performing kind acts before we fully understand kindness. But the act without the noticing remains mechanical. This lesson pairs the act with the attention — teaching children to see the effect of their care on others, which is what eventually produces the interior disposition rather than the performance.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can give two examples of kind acts and explain that kindness is a choice, not just a feeling.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to notice the effect of their kindness on others.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from reactive behavior toward deliberate, other-oriented care.

L05 Lesson 5: Telling the Truth

Why does telling the truth matter?

Why This Topic	Honesty is the virtue most immediately connected to trust — and trust is the foundation of every genuine relationship. The child who learns
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	early that truth-telling produces peace and connection, while lying produces a specific kind of internal discomfort, has learned something that lectures about honesty cannot produce.
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Content	Truth-telling as care for others, not as rule-following. The relief that comes with honesty as a felt, bodily experience. Stories about what happens when people lie and when they tell the truth. The concept that words should match what is real.
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Approach & Methods	Stories, role-play, teacher sharing a time they told a hard truth and what followed. The specific feeling of relief is named and honored.
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Teaching Principles	Connect virtue to feeling. Children learn honesty because it produces peace and genuine connection, not because it is commanded. The inner sense of rightness when truth is spoken is itself a kind of knowledge.
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Formation Ground	Every philosophical tradition that has thought seriously about character — from Plato's account of the philosopher who loves truth to Aristotle's virtue of truthfulness (aletheia) to the Stoic practice of speaking only what one believes — treats honesty not as a social convention but as an alignment with reality. To lie is to create a gap between words and the world. The child who feels that gap as discomfort has genuine moral perception.
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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain why telling the truth matters and identify one situation where it was hard.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to feel the difference — in their body — between speaking truthfully and not.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from truth-when-convenient toward a stable identity as someone who tells the truth.

L06 Lesson 6: Sharing

What happens when I give?

Why This Topic	Generosity is one of the most natural virtues in young children — it needs cultivation, not installation. The child who has genuinely experienced the warmth of giving — not the performance of giving to receive approval, but the real interior warmth — has the seed of genuine generosity.
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Content	Sharing time, toys, food, and attention. The difference between forced sharing and genuine giving. The joy of giving as an experience to be noticed and savored — not a duty to be performed.
Approach & Methods	Sharing circles, snack-sharing activities, gift-making for classmates. Teacher narrates the joy in giving genuinely, without performance.
Teaching Principles	Experience before concept. Let the child feel the warmth of giving before being told it is a virtue. The lived experience is the curriculum.
Formation Ground	Aristotle's virtue of generosity (eleutheriotēs) — the disposition to give the right things to the right people at the right time — begins here, in the five-year-old who gives their snack because they noticed someone had none. Generosity cannot be installed by command. It grows from the experience of giving that is genuinely free.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can describe the feeling of giving and name one person they can give to this week.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to notice genuine joy arising from generous action.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from self-absorption toward genuinely other-oriented generosity.

L07 Lesson 7: Thank You

What am I grateful for?

Why This Topic	Gratitude is simultaneously a virtue, a psychological state, and a way of seeing the world. Substantial research confirms its connection to wellbeing, moral development, and the capacity for genuine relationship. But more fundamentally: the grateful person sees correctly — they see that what they have is given, not earned.
Content	Gratitude as noticing: what do I have that I did not earn? The body, the family, language, sight, warmth, existence itself. Gratitude to people who care for me. The concept that most of what we have is invisible gift.
Approach & Methods	Gratitude journals (drawings), thank-you projects for parents, outdoor walks noticing beauty. Teacher models genuine gratitude — not performed, but real.

Teaching Principles	Gratitude before theology. Let the child feel the full weight of giftedness before any larger framework is offered. The experience produces the readiness for what follows in later grades.
Formation Ground	The Stoics practiced gratitude as a philosophical discipline: Marcus Aurelius begins his <i>Meditations</i> with an inventory of what he has received from others. Modern psychological research (Emmons, McCullough) confirms that gratitude practice measurably increases wellbeing, prosocial behavior, and moral perception. The grateful person sees more truly — and because they see more truly, they act more rightly.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can list three things they are grateful for and explain that gratitude means noticing gifts.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to notice the accumulated gift of their existence.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from taking existence for granted toward a habitual posture of genuine gratitude.

L08 Lesson 8: We Are Different and the Same

How can people be different and still belong?

Why This Topic	Human diversity is not a problem to be solved — it is a feature of the world worth wondering at. The child who encounters difference with curiosity rather than anxiety has a fundamentally different moral posture from one who encounters it with fear. This lesson protects the child's natural openness.
Content	Differences in family, food, language, and appearance explored with wonder and pride. Unity in shared humanity, shared needs, shared capacity for joy and suffering and love. Difference as the occasion for discovery, not division.
Approach & Methods	Cultural sharing days, map explorations, stories from different communities. Teacher celebrates diversity explicitly and with genuine interest.
Teaching Principles	Wonder before judgment. The child's natural openness to difference is the formation posture we want — the curriculum's task is to protect it from the categorizing impulse that social pressure will later install.

Formation Ground	Aristotle, in his <i>Politics</i> , understood that the human being is a social animal whose flourishing requires genuine community with others. But the community that enables flourishing is not one of uniformity — it is one in which different contributions make the whole more complete. The child who can genuinely delight in difference has the foundation for both justice and friendship.
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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can name two differences between themselves and a classmate and explain that difference is interesting rather than threatening.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to feel curiosity rather than anxiety at human difference.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from exclusionary thinking toward genuine appreciation of human variety.

L09 Lesson 9: Making Mistakes Is Okay

What do I do when I do something wrong?

Why This Topic	The relationship with moral failure is formed early and durably. A shame-based relationship with mistakes produces perfectionism or concealment — both of which prevent genuine character development. The curriculum must plant, from the very beginning, the capacity for honest acknowledgment and genuine repair.
Content	The difference between a mistake and being bad. How to say sorry genuinely, make it right, and start again. Teacher models making and owning a mistake with ease and dignity — without performance of self-flagellation.
Approach & Methods	Story circles about characters who make mistakes and recover, repair activities, classroom apology and repair rituals. Teacher models the process visibly.
Teaching Principles	Separate the act from the self. 'You made a mistake' is not 'you are bad.' This distinction is the seed of both psychological health and genuine moral agency. The child who confuses the two cannot develop character — they can only defend against evidence of inadequacy.
Formation Ground	Carol Dweck's research on growth mindset demonstrates empirically what Aristotle understood philosophically: character is not a fixed trait but a developing capacity. The child who treats mistakes as

	evidence of fixed badness cannot develop. The child who treats mistakes as information about what needs to change can. Genuine repair — not mere apology — is the moral skill this lesson begins to build.
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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can describe the steps of a genuine apology: name what happened, say sorry, make it right.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to feel the difference between shame (hiding) and accountability (repair).
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from shame-based concealment toward accountable, repair-oriented moral agency.

L10 Lesson 10: Who Made the World?

Where did everything come from — and is it still being made?

Why This Topic	This question is not introduced as a doctrinal claim but as a lived wonder — the question that arises naturally in any child who truly looks at the world. The curriculum's philosophical commitment — that existence is meaningful and that the cosmos is not merely mechanism — begins here, held as wonder before it is held as argument.
Content	The world is not merely made — it is continuously alive, astonishing, and generous. Seeds, animals, light, water, the child's own breathing — all of them sources of genuine wonder. The question 'who made this?' arises naturally from genuine attention. The curriculum protects the space for that question without forcing a premature answer.
Approach & Methods	Nature walks, science-and-wonder integration, stories of creation from multiple traditions, drawing what they find beautiful and strange. Teacher models genuine awe — not performance — at the existence of ordinary things.
Teaching Principles	Protect the question. The child who asks 'but who made God?' is not being difficult — they are doing philosophy. Receive the question with delight, not deflection. The wonder is more formative than any answer.
Formation Ground	The curriculum takes a philosophical position here that it holds throughout the K-12 arc: the cosmos is not merely a collection of mechanisms but a reality that is beautiful, meaningful, and worthy of the deepest attention. This position is shared by Aristotle (the cosmos as ordered toward ends), by the major wisdom traditions of humanity,

	and by many modern thinkers from Einstein ('the most incomprehensible thing about the universe is that it is comprehensible') to the philosopher of science Michael Polanyi. It is the ground of genuine wonder.
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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can describe two natural wonders and express that the world being beautiful is a reason for wonder.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to feel the aliveness of the natural world as something worth attending to deeply.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from a passive relationship with the natural world toward a sense of the cosmos as genuinely astonishing and worth wondering about.

GRADE 1 — Age 6–7

Habits, Feelings, and the Heart as a Mirror

Grade 1 deepens emotional literacy while introducing the most important single concept in the curriculum's formation arc: the self has an interior that can be cultivated or neglected, and that cultivation is what character is. The concept of the heart — or what developmental psychologists call the emotional-evaluative center of the person — is introduced as real, important, and capable of becoming clearer or more obscured. Formation, at its most fundamental, is the work of keeping that interior instrument clear. The teacher's own quality of presence remains the primary curriculum.

L01 Lesson 1: My Heart

What is in my heart?

Why This Topic

The interior life is real. This is the foundational claim of the entire curriculum, and it is introduced here as an experience before it is introduced as a concept. The child who learns to attend to their interior — what they love, what troubles them, what makes them feel light or heavy — has the beginning of the self-knowledge that genuine character requires.

Content

The heart as center: what do I love? What makes my heart feel heavy or light? The idea that the interior can be more or less clear — like a mirror that can be clean or clouded. What we put into our minds and what we choose to notice either clears or clouds the mirror.

Approach & Methods

Heart-drawing activities, heart maps, stories about characters whose hearts change. Teacher shares genuinely what is in their own heart — with honesty and without performance.

Teaching Principles

Interior access before external behavior. The child's inner life matters more than their outer compliance. Reach the interior before asking for the behavior. Character that is not rooted in the interior is performance, not formation.

Formation Ground

Al-Ghazālī, the 11th-century philosopher and psychologist, used the image of the heart as a mirror that reflects reality clearly when polished and distortedly when obscured by the accumulation of distraction and desire. This image — shared across traditions from Plato's account of the soul to modern contemplative psychology — captures what the curriculum's formation project is fundamentally about: not installing new content but clearing what already sees.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual

Students can explain that the heart is the center of who they are and name two things that are in their heart.

Reflective

This lesson creates conditions for students to turn attention inward toward the heart as a real and important place.

Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from external behavior-focus toward genuine interior awareness.
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L02 Lesson 2: Being Brave

What does courage feel like in my body?

Why This Topic	Courage is introduced through the felt experience of acting despite fear — not the elimination of fear. This lesson plants the definitional seed that will be returned to across the entire K-12 arc: courage is not fearlessness, it is action despite fear. The child who has this definition cannot be disqualified from courage by the presence of fear.
Content	Fear as a real feeling, not a weakness. The difference between being scared and giving up. Courage as doing the right thing even when your heart is beating fast. Small examples from the child's own experience where they kept going despite fear.
Approach & Methods	Personal courage stories, role-play of small brave acts. Teacher shares a time they were scared and kept going anyway.
Teaching Principles	Normalize fear. Courage is not fearlessness. The child who believes courage means not feeling fear will never identify as courageous — and will miss the virtue their entire life. This definitional repair is more important than any encouragement to 'be brave.'
Formation Ground	Aristotle's account of courage (andreia) is foundational: the courageous person is not the one who feels no fear but the one whose fear response is calibrated to actual danger and who acts rightly regardless. The Stoics added: it is the very presence of fear that makes courage meaningful. Modern developmental psychology confirms: the capacity to act despite discomfort — not the absence of discomfort — is what predicts long-term moral and personal functioning.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can define courage as acting rightly despite fear and give one example from their own life.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to recognize their own small acts of courage as genuine courage.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from 'I am not brave because I feel scared' toward genuine embodied courage.

L03 Lesson 3: When I'm Angry

What can I do when I feel angry?

Why This Topic	Anger is the emotion most connected to moral failure in childhood and most in need of early formation. The curriculum does not suppress it — it honors its intelligence. Anger is information about violated values. The question is not whether to feel angry but what to do with what the anger is pointing at.
Content	Anger as information: what value has been violated? The difference between feeling angry and acting from anger. Strategies for the body when anger is high. The concept that the same energy, directed well, can become the force behind genuine moral conviction.
Approach & Methods	Anger thermometer, freeze-frame role plays, breathing practices, stories. Teacher models their own relationship with anger honestly.
Teaching Principles	Name the emotion, not the child. 'You are feeling angry' is not 'you are being bad.' The feeling is valid; the action is the choice. This distinction is the beginning of genuine moral agency.
Formation Ground	Aristotle's treatment of anger in the Nicomachean Ethics is subtle and important: anger is not a vice. Feeling no anger at genuine injustice is a failure of moral perception. The virtue is feeling the right amount of anger, at the right things, at the right time — and choosing one's response deliberately. This curriculum teaches children to use anger as information rather than to suppress or perform it.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can name what anger feels like in their body and identify one strategy for acting wisely when angry.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to notice anger as information before simply reacting to it.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from automatic acting-out of anger toward the capacity to observe it and choose a response.

L04 Lesson 4: Keeping Promises

What happens when I break a promise?

Why This Topic	Promise-keeping introduces the child to the structure of covenant —
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	the binding of one's word to reality, the making of oneself accountable to what was said. This is the earliest form of integrity: the alignment of inner commitment with outer expression.
Content	What a promise is, why it matters, what it feels like to be let down by one, and what it feels like to keep one. The concept that a person who keeps their promises becomes a certain kind of person — trustworthy, reliable, someone others can count on.
Approach & Methods	Promise-making rituals in class, stories about promises kept and broken. Teacher models keeping a promise made to students — publicly and without ceremony.
Teaching Principles	Commitment as identity. 'I am a person who keeps promises' is an identity statement, not a rule compliance. The formation goal is not just keeping this promise but building the character that keeps promises as a matter of who one is.
Formation Ground	The Stoics emphasized fidelity to one's word as a cornerstone of the good character — not because breaking promises incurs punishment but because the person who breaks promises is fragmenting their own integrity. To say one thing and do another is to become divided against oneself. Promise-keeping is the earliest practice of the integration the curriculum works toward across twelve years.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain why keeping promises matters and identify one promise they can make and keep this week.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to feel the weight of their word as something real.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from casual speech toward treating one's word as a genuine commitment.

L05 Lesson 5: Friends

What makes a real friend?

Why This Topic	Friendship is the first site of genuine moral complexity for children. Loyalty, exclusion, conflict, and genuine care all appear here. And the question of who one becomes in the company of certain people is one of the most important formation questions of the entire curriculum.
Content	What real friendship requires: honesty, loyalty, showing up, conflict

	and repair. The difference between a friend who tells you what you want to hear and one who tells you what you need. The concept that companions shape us — that who we walk with matters.
Approach & Methods	Friend mapping, stories about friendship tested by conflict, class discussions on inclusion. Teacher shares what friendship has meant to their own formation.
Teaching Principles	Depth over breadth. One real friend is worth ten acquaintances. Build the quality-over-quantity orientation from the beginning. And begin the concept — to be returned to at greater depth in later grades — that friendship is formative, not merely pleasant.
Formation Ground	Aristotle devoted two full books of the Nicomachean Ethics to friendship, calling it 'a virtue or implies virtue' and 'necessary for life.' The highest form of friendship, in his account, is not based on pleasure or utility but on genuine care for the other's character. The person who walks with people who are becoming genuinely good is being formed differently than the one who walks with people who are merely enjoyable. This seed is planted here.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can name two qualities of a real friend and explain the difference between a pleasant companion and a genuine friend.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to examine what their current friendships require of them.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from friendship-as-enjoyment toward friendship-as-mutual-formation.

L06 Lesson 6: Listening

Am I really listening?

Why This Topic	Attention is a moral act. To give another person your full, genuine attention is to say with your presence: you are real, what you are saying matters. The capacity for genuine listening is one of the rarest and most powerful virtues — and one of the least cultivated in an environment of chronic distraction.
Content	Listening with body, eyes, and heart. The difference between waiting to talk and actually hearing. What it feels like to be truly heard — and to be merely tolerated. The effect of genuine attention on the person who receives it.

Approach & Methods	Listening games, back-to-back drawing exercises, reflection on a time someone really listened. Teacher practices visible, deliberate listening during every class discussion — modeling is the primary instruction.
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Teaching Principles	Make the invisible visible. Listening is invisible but its effects are immediate. Help children see what their attention does to others. The moral quality of attention can be felt before it can be theorized.
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Formation Ground	The philosopher Simone Weil wrote that 'attention is the rarest and purest form of generosity.' For Weil, genuine attention — the complete suspension of one's own concerns in order to receive another person — is one of the highest moral acts available to a human being. Modern research on relationships confirms: feeling genuinely heard is one of the most powerful experiences of human connection. The capacity to give that gift is a moral capacity, and it begins with six-year-olds learning to actually listen.
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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can demonstrate active listening posture and explain what makes listening real versus pretend.
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Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to notice the difference between their listening and not-listening in terms of what they receive from others.
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Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from distracted, self-focused engagement toward genuinely attentive presence.
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L07 Lesson 7: The World Is Beautiful

Why is the world so beautiful?

Why This Topic	This lesson is an exercise in what the philosopher Iris Murdoch called 'just and loving attention' — the capacity to genuinely see what is there, rather than using it. The world is not merely functional. It is beautiful. And the question of why there is beauty at all is one of the most philosophically significant questions a human being can ask.
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Content	Natural beauty explored in depth: light, color, sound, smell, texture, the strangeness of ordinary things. The question of beauty as a question about its source. Why should a universe be beautiful? What does it mean that human beings are capable of recognizing beauty at all?
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Approach & Methods	Outdoor sensory walk, art creation from nature, music and movement. Teacher names beauty explicitly, slowly, without rushing past it.
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Teaching Principles	Slow down to see. Beauty is everywhere but invisible to the rushed and distracted. Training attention to beauty is not aesthetic education — it is moral education. The capacity to see beauty truly is the same capacity required for genuine moral perception.
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Formation Ground	The philosopher Iris Murdoch argued that the ability to see something truly — including beauty — requires the 'unselfing' of the ego, the temporary suspension of self-concern that allows genuine perception. Dostoevsky famously wrote that 'beauty will save the world' — not beauty as decoration but beauty as the disclosure of a reality that is not reducible to mechanism. This curriculum takes seriously the formation of aesthetic perception as a moral capacity.
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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can describe two specific natural wonders they find beautiful and express genuine wonder at them.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to slow down and actually see beauty rather than pass through it.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from indifference to the natural world toward a habitual sense of wonder at its beauty.

L08 Lesson 8: Being Fair

What is fair, and why does it matter?

Why This Topic	The child's acute sensitivity to injustice is a moral intuition worth taking seriously. The curriculum validates it rather than suppresses it — and begins the long work of refining it into genuine justice rather than mere preference for one's own advantage.
Content	Fair vs. unfair in concrete classroom situations. What to do when something is unfair. Standing up for fairness for others, not just oneself. The concept that fairness matters even when it costs something.
Approach & Methods	Fairness scenarios, structured discussion, role-play of speaking up. Teacher acknowledges genuinely when something is unfair — modeling honest assessment over institutional smoothing.
Teaching Principles	Validate the sense of injustice. The child who says 'that's not fair' is doing moral reasoning. Train that impulse rather than silencing it. The impulse toward fairness is the beginning of the virtue of justice — and it is the curriculum's task to refine, not suppress it.

Formation Ground	Aristotle's virtue of justice is the most social of the virtues — it always involves other people. And for Aristotle, justice begins not with rules but with perception: the just person is one who sees clearly what each situation requires and gives each person what they are owed. The child's natural sensitivity to unfairness is a primitive form of this perceptual capacity. The curriculum's task is to develop it, not domesticate it.
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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain what fairness means and give an example of standing up for fairness for someone else.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to feel the difference between a situation that is genuinely fair and one that is not.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from fairness-for-me toward genuine other-directed justice.

L09 Lesson 9: Helping Without Being Asked

Can I notice when someone needs help?

Why This Topic	Initiative in service is more developed than compliance. This lesson trains what philosophers call moral perception — the ability to see what a situation requires without being told. This is the earliest form of practical wisdom (phronesis), and it begins with the simple act of noticing.
Content	The difference between helping when told and helping because you noticed. The quality of attention required to see another's need before it is announced. The joy that comes from unexpected, unprompted care.
Approach & Methods	Observation games, 'help spotter' roles, stories about characters who help before being asked. Teacher explicitly appreciates initiative over compliance.
Teaching Principles	Moral perception before moral action. You cannot help what you do not see. Train the eyes and the attention before asking for the hands. The capacity to notice is the precondition of the capacity to act.
Formation Ground	Aristotle's concept of phronesis — practical wisdom — is the capacity to perceive what a situation actually requires and to respond appropriately. It cannot be reduced to rule-following because it requires seeing the particular situation. The child who helps before

	being asked is exercising an early form of this perception: they have genuinely looked at another person and seen what they need. This is moral insight, not merely good behavior.
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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can describe the difference between helping when asked and helping before being asked, and practice noticing a need in the classroom.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to notice others' needs without prompting.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from self-focused awareness toward other-oriented moral perception.

L10 Lesson 10: Before I Sleep

What happened in my heart today?

Why This Topic	Honest self-accounting — the gentle, non-judgmental review of the day from the inside — is introduced here as a practice rather than a concept. This is the earliest version of the reflective practice that runs as a spine through the entire K-12 arc. The child who learns to look honestly at their own day has begun the lifelong practice of self-knowledge.
Content	What was good today? Was there a moment I wish I had chosen differently? What am I grateful for? What do I want to do differently tomorrow? Gentle self-review without shame — curiosity rather than judgment.
Approach & Methods	'Three things' reflection practice, drawing journal. Teacher models the practice openly, including their own small regrets and genuine gratitudes.
Teaching Principles	Reflection without judgment. The goal is interior awareness, not self-punishment. Plant curiosity about the inner life rather than fear of it. The child who is ashamed of their interior will hide it — from themselves first, and then from everyone else.
Formation Ground	The philosopher Socrates famously held that 'the unexamined life is not worth living.' The practice introduced here is the simplest possible form of that examination: a five-year-old asking, before sleep, what happened in their heart today. Marcus Aurelius did this every night, as did Benjamin Franklin, as did figures across every culture that has taken character seriously. The practice is universal precisely

	because the need for self-knowledge is universal.
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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can describe the self-accounting practice and identify one thing they did well and one they want to do differently tomorrow.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to end the day with gentle, honest self-awareness rather than unconscious drift.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from no self-reflection toward a daily practice of honest interior review.

GRADE 2 — Age 7–8

Identity, Repair, and the Self as a Story Being Written

Grade 2 develops the concept of the self as continuous across time — a story with a narrator. Children begin to understand that their character is not fixed but forming; that mistakes can be genuinely repaired; and that they belong to something larger than themselves. The concept of stewardship appears: everything we have is held in trust, not owned. The question of what we love begins to receive attention — because what we love shapes who we are becoming.

L01 Lesson 1: My Name and My Story

Who am I, and how do I know?

Why This Topic

Narrative identity — the self as a story — is introduced. Before philosophy can address identity, the child needs a story to inhabit. That story connects them to family, community, history, and something larger than their individual experience. It is the foundation on which all later self-knowledge rests.

Content

Family stories, name meanings, where I come from, what I have done that I am proud of. The self as a continuous story with depth behind it and possibility ahead. The concept that who I am now is part of a longer story that began before me and will continue after me.

Approach & Methods

Family interview projects, personal timeline drawings, story-sharing circles. Teacher shares their own name story and what it has meant.

Teaching Principles

Identity before ideology. The child needs a story before a philosophy. Give them the story first — the philosophy will have something to work with. A child with no story is infinitely more vulnerable to having their story written by external forces.

Formation Ground

The philosopher Paul Ricoeur argued that personal identity is fundamentally narrative: we are the stories we tell about ourselves, and those stories are located within larger stories — family, community, history, civilization. Erik Erikson's developmental psychology confirms: children in this stage are forming the earliest version of their life narrative. The quality of that narrative — its depth, its connections, its sense of continuity — predicts the stability of later identity formation.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual

Students can share their name's meaning, one family story, and describe themselves as a story that is still being written.

Reflective

This lesson creates conditions for students to feel that their life has depth, continuity, and direction.

Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from identity-as-fixed-thing toward identity-as-story-being-written.
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L02 Lesson 2: Being Patient

What do I do when I have to wait?

Why This Topic	Patience introduced not as passive waiting but as active perseverance — the capacity to hold one's orientation under pressure, to not let difficulty determine one's direction. This is one of the most practically important character capacities a human being can have, and its formation begins in childhood.
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Content	The difference between giving up and pausing. Patience with things that are hard, with people who frustrate us, with ourselves when we fail. Some good things take a long time and the waiting is part of the gift — the difficulty is not evidence that something is wrong.
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Approach & Methods	Patience challenges requiring sustained time, stories of patient characters, discussion of a hard thing they kept trying. Teacher models patience visibly and names it.
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Teaching Principles	Normalize the difficult. Difficulty is not evidence that something is wrong. Sometimes it is evidence that something important is being built. The child who believes difficulty means 'this isn't for me' will abandon every genuinely worthwhile project they attempt.
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Formation Ground	The Stoics made patience — the endurance of what cannot be changed and the persistence through what can be changed — central to their ethics. Modern developmental psychology (Angela Duckworth's grit research, Walter Mischel's work on delay of gratification) confirms empirically what the philosophical tradition knew: the capacity to persist through difficulty is one of the strongest predictors of long-term flourishing in every domain of life.
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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain that patience means holding their orientation under pressure and give one example.
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Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to experience the inner sense of holding firm when something is difficult.
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Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from giving up at difficulty toward the capacity to hold one's orientation through sustained challenge.
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L03 Lesson 3: Saying Sorry and Meaning It

What does a real apology look like?

Why This Topic	Moral repair — naming a wrong, taking genuine responsibility, and restoring a relationship — is one of the most important moral competencies a human being can develop, and one of the least explicitly taught. This lesson gives it structure and makes it possible to practice.
Content	The components of genuine apology: naming what happened without excuse, taking responsibility, expressing care for the person hurt, and changing the behavior. The difference between 'I'm sorry you felt that way' and 'I'm sorry for what I did and what it cost you.'
Approach & Methods	Repair role-plays, apology letter writing (drawing-based), class discussions of recent conflicts handled well. Teacher models apologizing to students genuinely — without performance.
Teaching Principles	Make repair normal. A class culture where apology is natural and respected changes everything about how moral failure is processed. The student who can apologize genuinely is demonstrating one of the highest moral capacities: the willingness to face what they have done and take responsibility for it.
Formation Ground	Aristotle understood justice as giving each person what they are owed — and when we have wronged someone, what we owe them is genuine repair. Modern research on forgiveness and repair (Worthington, McCullough) confirms: the components of a genuine apology are specific and learnable, and they matter enormously for the wellbeing of both parties. This lesson teaches the structure because genuine repair cannot happen if the structure is not known.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can name the four parts of a genuine apology and practice giving one.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to distinguish between a real apology and a performance of one.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from defensive denial or empty apology toward genuine accountability and repair.

L04 Lesson 4: Why Do We Have Rules?

Are rules fair?

Why This Topic	Rules introduced not as arbitrary authority demands but as expressions of a deeper concern for the welfare of each person and the community. This is the beginning of the distinction between law and justice — a distinction the curriculum returns to at greater philosophical depth in later grades.
Content	What would happen without rules? Which rules do we have and why? Are all rules fair? What do you do when a rule seems genuinely unjust? The concept of rule as serving the community rather than serving the authority.
Approach & Methods	Classroom simulation without rules, rule-making exercise for the class, discussion of a rule students think is unfair. Teacher engages with the critique honestly.
Teaching Principles	Engage the critique honestly. The child who asks 'why?' about a rule is doing moral reasoning. Honor it. The formation goal is not rule-following — it is the understanding of what rules are for and the capacity to evaluate them.
Formation Ground	The philosophical tradition from Plato through Aristotle through the natural law tradition to contemporary political philosophy has consistently distinguished between rules that serve genuine human good and rules that serve the interests of power. The child who learns to ask 'what is this rule for?' is learning the most important political and moral question available. Aristotle: 'The rule of law is preferable to the rule of any individual' — but law itself must be evaluated against justice.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain why rules exist and identify one rule they think is genuinely fair and one they have genuine questions about.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to think about rules as serving a purpose rather than as arbitrary demands.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from rule-following as compliance toward understanding rules as expressions of care for the community.

L05 Lesson 5: Leaders Help Others

What is a leader for?

Why This Topic	Leadership introduced as service rather than power — as the assumption of responsibility for the welfare of others, not the acquisition of authority over them. This is the seed of the understanding of leadership as a moral category, not merely a social or positional one.
Content	Leaders in the classroom, at home, in history. What makes a leader genuinely good? The difference between a leader who takes and a leader who gives. The concept that leadership is always answerable — to those who are led, and to something larger than one's own interests.
Approach & Methods	Leadership case studies from world history, classroom leadership roles, discussion of an admired leader and why. Teacher discusses their own experience of leadership honestly.
Teaching Principles	Leadership as stewardship, not ownership. The one who leads does not own what they lead — they hold it in trust. This is the beginning of the concept that every position of genuine authority is a moral responsibility, not a privilege.
Formation Ground	Aristotle's concept of political leadership at its best is not the imposition of the leader's will but the cultivation of the conditions for the community's flourishing. The Stoics: the leader is the one who takes the most responsibility, not the one who takes the most benefit. Modern leadership research (servant leadership, transformational leadership) confirms: the leaders who produce the best outcomes for their communities are those who understand their role as service.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain that leadership means serving others and give an example of a leader who helped rather than just commanded.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to notice leadership as service in the people around them.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from leadership-as-power toward leadership-as-responsibility.

L06 Lesson 6: The Earth Needs Us

Why should I care about the world around me?

Why This Topic	Environmental stewardship introduced as a moral category: we did not earn the world we inhabit, and we are responsible for what happens to it on our watch. The concept of the human being as a
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	custodian rather than an owner is one of the deepest formation concepts in the curriculum.
Content	Water, animals, plants, and the earth as things entrusted to our care. What we do to the natural world matters — not because it is a political cause but because we are responsible for what we have been given and for those who will come after us.
Approach & Methods	Nature care projects, water conservation experiments, stories of communities who care for the land. Teacher models genuine care for the classroom environment and names it as stewardship.
Teaching Principles	Stewardship before environmentalism. The motivation is moral and philosophical, not political. We care for the natural world because we did not make it, because it is more than we understand, and because how we treat it is a reflection of our character — of whether we are people who leave things better or worse than we found them.
Formation Ground	The philosopher Aldo Leopold's 'land ethic' — the extension of the ethical community to include the land and all its inhabitants — represents one of the most important developments in moral philosophy of the 20th century. The ancient Greek concept of the cosmos as a living whole, the indigenous traditions' understanding of the human being as embedded in a web of relationships with the natural world, and the modern environmental ethics tradition all converge on the same insight: the human being's relationship to the natural world is a moral relationship.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain why caring for the earth is a responsibility and describe one way they can be a steward.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to feel responsibility toward the natural world, not merely enjoyment of it.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from user of the earth toward steward of the earth.

L07 Lesson 7: What I Love

Why do I love what I love?

Why This Topic	The first lesson explicitly on the structure of desire and the formation of love. What we love shapes who we are becoming — this is not a moral warning but a philosophical description of how the self develops. Making desire visible is the first step toward its formation.
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Content	Making a map of what they love: people, activities, things, experiences. Noticing that different people love different things. Beginning to ask: where does this love come from? What does loving this do to me?
Approach & Methods	Love maps (drawing), sharing circles, discussion of what they would miss most. Teacher shares what they genuinely love and why.
Teaching Principles	Love before law. Understanding what a student loves is the prerequisite for any genuine formation. The curriculum does not ask students to abandon their loves — it asks students to become conscious of them and, eventually, to examine whether they are ordered toward genuine good.
Formation Ground	Aristotle held that the fundamental orienting force of the soul is love — what we love determines the direction of our lives. Augustine: 'our heart is restless until it rests in You' — but even before the theological claim, the philosophical observation holds: the human being is always already loving something, always already moving toward something. The formation question is not whether to love but what to love and whether that love is well ordered.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can draw a love map and begin to notice what the things they love have in common.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to become conscious of their loves rather than simply having them unconsciously.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from unconscious desire toward growing awareness of what one loves and why.

L08 Lesson 8: People Who Inspired Me

What does a good person look like?

Why This Topic	Exemplar formation — the use of concrete moral models — is among the most powerful pedagogical tools in character education. This lesson makes exemplars explicit and begins developing the capacity for formative admiration: seeing in another what one wishes to become.
Content	People in their lives, in history, and across traditions who demonstrated courage, kindness, honesty, and love. What made them special? What specifically did they do? And — can I be like them?

Approach & Methods	Exemplar sharing from students' lives, stories from world history and multiple traditions. Teacher shares their own exemplars and what seeing them did to their own formation.
Teaching Principles	Make the exemplar human. The hero who feels impossible to emulate inspires but does not form. Show the struggle, the fear, the doubt alongside the greatness. The exemplar's humanity is what makes their character available for imitation.
Formation Ground	Aristotle's concept of the virtuous person as the standard of virtue — we know what courage is by looking at the courageous person, not by consulting a definition — places exemplar formation at the center of moral education. Albert Bandura's social learning theory confirms empirically: observational learning from models is one of the most powerful mechanisms of character formation available. The curriculum uses this deliberately.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can name two people who inspire them and explain specifically what quality they demonstrated.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to see in others what they wish to become.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from passive admiration of good people toward active imitation of their specific qualities.

L09 Lesson 9: Honest When It Is Hard

Why is honesty sometimes scary?

Why This Topic	The intersection of courage and truth — the capacity to say what is real when there is something to lose. The curriculum returns to honesty here at a deeper level: not honesty as a social courtesy but honesty as a virtue that costs something and is chosen anyway.
Content	Times when truth is hard: admitting a mistake, telling a friend something difficult, disagreeing with someone who has more power. The specific relief and respect that tend to follow genuine honesty. The cost acknowledged before the virtue is asked for.
Approach & Methods	Story-based exploration of hard-truth scenarios, reflection on a time they were honest when it cost them. Teacher shares a hard-truth story from their own life.

Teaching Principles	Honor the cost. Honesty is not free, and children know it. Acknowledging the real difficulty before asking for the virtue is both more honest and more effective than treating honesty as easy.
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Formation Ground	The Stoic tradition consistently distinguished between social agreeableness and genuine honesty — and consistently preferred the latter even when it was costly. The Stoic sage speaks what is true even when the audience wants to hear something else. This is not rudeness — it is the courage to respect the other person enough to tell them the truth. The child who learns this is learning one of the foundational virtues of genuine friendship and genuine character.
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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain why honesty sometimes costs something and describe one situation where they chose honesty despite the cost.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to recognize the gap between what they want to say and what is true — and to choose truth.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from honesty-when-safe toward a stable commitment to honesty regardless of cost.

L10 Lesson 10: Who Is the Source?

What is behind all the beauty and order in the world?

Why This Topic	The curriculum's philosophical position — that the world is not merely mechanism but a reality oriented toward something that transcends it — is introduced here experientially. Not as religious doctrine requiring assent but as a philosophical question that arises naturally from genuine attention to the world.
Content	The world's beauty, order, and generosity as a question: is all of this an accident, or does it point toward something? Different traditions have answered this question differently, and all serious thinkers have had to grapple with it. The curriculum takes seriously the possibility that the cosmos is not merely mechanism — and invites students to wonder about it.
Approach & Methods	Nature exploration framed philosophically, stories of wonder from multiple traditions, reflection on experiences of beauty that felt like more than aesthetic pleasure. Teacher models reverent wonder.
Teaching Principles	Experiential philosophical inquiry first. The question is introduced as a genuine question — one that every serious thinker has had to face

	— not as a doctrinal answer to be received. The wonder is more formative than any premature resolution.
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Formation Ground	The philosopher Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz famously asked: 'Why is there something rather than nothing?' This is the most fundamental philosophical question available, and it arises naturally from genuine attention to the existence of anything at all. Every major tradition of thought — from Aristotle's unmoved mover through the great theistic traditions through Einstein's sense of the 'mysterious' — has recognized that the existence of an ordered, beautiful, intelligible cosmos requires an account that goes beyond mechanism. The curriculum takes this seriously as a philosophical position.
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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can describe the question of 'what is behind the world' and explain why it is a question worth wondering about.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to feel the philosophical depth of the question of existence.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from taking the world's existence for granted toward genuine wonder about why there is something rather than nothing.

GRADE 3 — Age 8–9

Inner Life, Habits, and the World as a Book of Signs

Grade 3 deepens the capacity for reflection while introducing two of the most important insights of the curriculum: that the natural world is not merely functional but meaningful — it discloses something about the nature of reality — and that knowledge has sources beyond the senses. The concept of habit as the actual mechanism of character formation is made explicit. Simple Socratic dialogue begins: the teacher asks questions without knowing the answer, and the class thinks together toward something neither has fully grasped.

L01 Lesson 1: Who Am I Really?

Is there a me behind the me that people see?

Why This Topic

The distinction between the social self and the interior self — introduced as a genuine question rather than a resolved answer. This is the philosophical seed from which all later self-knowledge work grows. The student who has genuinely encountered this question stands on completely different ground from one who has not.

Content

The difference between who I am at school, at home, with friends, and alone. Which is the real me? The concept of an original nature — a self that was present before social conditioning shaped it — that is discoverable rather than constructed.

Approach & Methods

Dramatic role exploration, reflection journaling, class discussion on which self feels most real. Teacher discusses their own experience of multiple selves with genuine honesty.

Teaching Principles

Invite the question without forcing the answer. The goal is the awareness that identity is deeper than any social presentation — not the provision of a pre-packaged answer. This awareness is itself a form of knowledge, and it is one that many adults never arrive at.

Formation Ground

Plato's allegory of the cave describes human beings who mistake the shadows on the wall for reality. The philosophical task is to turn around — to see what is actually there rather than what convention says is there. The concept of an original nature beneath social overlay appears across traditions: Rousseau's natural goodness, Confucius's heaven-given nature (天命), the Romantic tradition's authentic self, and modern developmental psychology's concept of the 'true self.' They all point at the same insight: there is a self beneath the performance, and it is worth discovering.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual

Students can distinguish between their social self and their interior self and explain which feels most genuinely them.

Reflective

This lesson creates conditions for students to notice the gap between

	who they perform and who they are.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from identification with social roles toward awareness of the authentic self beneath them.

L02 Lesson 2: The Voices in My Head

Who is speaking when I think?

Why This Topic	Inner dialogue made visible. Students discover they have thoughts about their thoughts — and that this meta-awareness is a faculty that can be developed. The interior life has structure; it is not an undifferentiated flow. And not everything the inner narrator says is true.
Content	The inner narrator: the voice that says 'I'm not good enough,' 'I can't do this.' Where do these voices come from? Do they always tell the truth? The insight that we are not obligated to believe everything we think — that there is a difference between a thought arising and that thought being true.
Approach & Methods	Thought-bubble activities, character voices in stories, teacher models inner dialogue aloud. Reflection journal entries on the inner voice.
Teaching Principles	Make the invisible audible. The moment a student can name an inner voice, they have created space between themselves and it. That space is the beginning of genuine agency. Before you can govern the mind, you must be able to observe it.
Formation Ground	The Stoic practice of examining one's own impressions (phantasiai) — asking whether the thought that has arisen reflects reality or distortion — is one of the most sophisticated psychological practices available in the ancient world. Modern cognitive therapy (Aaron Beck, Albert Ellis) has rediscovered the same insight: many psychological difficulties arise not from the situations people are in but from the automatic thoughts they have about those situations. The capacity to observe one's own thinking — metacognition — is a foundational cognitive and moral capacity.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can identify two types of inner voices (helpful and unhelpful) and practice questioning whether an inner voice is telling the truth.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to observe their inner narrator rather than simply being it.

Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from automatic belief in inner voices toward critical, curious awareness of them.
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L03 Lesson 3: Courage Is Not Fearlessness

What is the difference between being brave and not being scared?

Why This Topic	Definitional work that will last a lifetime. The student who believes courage means not feeling fear will never identify as courageous — and will spend their life waiting for a feeling of fearlessness that genuine courage does not require. This lesson does the definitional repair before the virtue can be genuinely claimed.
Content	The precise definition: courage is acting rightly despite fear. Stories of people who were terrified and acted anyway — people whose fear was real and whose action was therefore genuinely courageous. Discussion of their own small acts of genuine courage.
Approach & Methods	Courage stories from students' own lives, world history case studies, teacher shares a fear they acted through. Class constructs its own definition together.
Teaching Principles	Redefine before reinforcing. Students cannot embody a virtue whose definition they have wrong. This lesson is primarily definitional — and definitions matter enormously for formation.
Formation Ground	Aristotle's account of courage (andreia) is the most precise available: courage is the mean between cowardice (too little response to danger) and rashness (too much). The courageous person feels appropriate fear in response to genuine danger — and acts rightly regardless. The philosopher who feels no fear in the face of genuine danger is not courageous but has either a defective fear response or a defective perception of the situation. Courage is an achievement precisely because fear is real.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can define courage accurately (acting rightly despite fear) and distinguish it from fearlessness.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to recognize their own small acts of courage as genuine courage.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from 'I am not brave because I feel scared' toward genuine embodied courage.

L04 Lesson 4: Being Fair to Everyone

Does fairness mean treating everyone the same?

Why This Topic	Justice deepened: equal treatment is sometimes unjust. The concept of equity — giving each person what they genuinely need and are genuinely owed — requires seeing the individual, not just applying the rule uniformly. This is one of the most important moral insights available to an eight-year-old.
Content	Scenarios where equal treatment is unfair. The equity/equality distinction. Justice as seeing the actual person and their actual situation, not as the application of a uniform rule. Standing up for someone who cannot stand up for themselves.
Approach & Methods	Fairness dilemma discussions, story analysis, simple debate format introduced. Teacher presents a genuine dilemma without a clean resolution.
Teaching Principles	Hold the complexity. The student who discovers that justice is more complicated than sameness has taken a genuine intellectual step forward. Protecting them from this complexity does not protect their moral development — it prevents it.
Formation Ground	Aristotle's concept of justice as 'giving to each what they are owed' — proportionate to their situation, their contribution, their need — is the most influential account of justice in the philosophical tradition. The modern philosopher John Rawls added: to know what is just, imagine you did not know which position in society you would occupy. Both accounts converge: justice is not uniformity but proportionate responsiveness to what each person actually needs and deserves.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can distinguish between equal treatment and equitable treatment and give an example of each.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to feel the inadequacy of simple sameness as a definition of justice.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from rules-based fairness toward person-sensitive, perception-based justice.

L05 Lesson 5: Habits Make Character

Why This Topic	Habituation — the insight that character is formed by what we do repeatedly, not by what we intend or what we know — is introduced explicitly. This is the single most important insight about how character development actually works, and it is one that most character education programs fail to transmit clearly.
Content	The connection between repeated actions and the kind of person one is becoming. Examples from sport, language, kindness, and attention. The concept of the compounding effect of small daily choices — every choice is building something, and the question is what.
Approach & Methods	Habit tracking (one week), stories of habit formation, discussion of a habit to build or change. Teacher shares a habit they are working on and what it has taken.
Teaching Principles	Long-term thinking. Help students see across time. The daily choice to be honest or dishonest is building something — the question is what. Aristotle: 'We are what we repeatedly do. Excellence, then, is not an act, but a habit.'
Formation Ground	Aristotle's concept of habituation (ēthos → ēthika — from habit to ethics, the very root of our word 'ethics') is the foundation of his entire moral philosophy. Character virtues are not innate; they are formed by repeated practice. Ibn Khaldūn (14th-century historian and social philosopher) refined this insight: the deeply embodied disposition (malaka) formed by sustained practice is different in kind from mere knowledge about virtue. Charles Duhigg's modern research on habits confirms: the neurological architecture of habit formation is exactly as Aristotle described — cue, routine, reward — and character is the accumulated result.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain that character is formed by habits and identify one habit they want to build.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to see across time — to notice that today's choices are building tomorrow's character.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from unconscious habit toward deliberate character construction.

L06 Lesson 6: Where Does Knowledge Come From?

Why This Topic	The epistemology question — how we know what we know — introduced simply but seriously. In an age of viral misinformation, manufactured certainty, and epistemological chaos, this may be the most practically urgent formation topic in the curriculum.
Content	Senses, reasoning, reliable testimony, and direct experience introduced as sources of knowledge. The limits of each. The difference between 'I feel,' 'I think,' and 'I know.' The concept that not knowing is sometimes the most honest position.
Approach & Methods	Knowledge source sorting activities, simple experiment contrasting feeling with knowing. Teacher models intellectual humility openly.
Teaching Principles	Introduce uncertainty as intellectual strength. The person who knows the limits of their knowledge is more trustworthy — and more genuinely knowledgeable — than the one who claims certainty about everything. Intellectual humility is a virtue, not a weakness.
Formation Ground	The philosopher John Locke distinguished between what we can know with certainty, what we can know with probability, and what we merely believe. The philosopher W.K. Clifford later argued that 'it is wrong always, everywhere, and for anyone to believe anything upon insufficient evidence.' While this is an extreme position, the underlying insight is important: the epistemic virtues — intellectual humility, calibrated confidence, honest acknowledgment of uncertainty — are moral virtues, not merely cognitive ones.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can name three sources of knowledge and identify which source each of several claims comes from.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to ask 'how do I know?' before accepting something as true.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from accepting claims on authority toward epistemic curiosity about sources.

L07 Lesson 7: What Makes a Good Friend?

Can I be the kind of friend I want to have?

Why This Topic	Friendship ethics deepened: the virtue requirements of genuine friendship, its corruption under social pressure, and the courage required to be genuinely present to another person rather than merely pleasant. The concept of the friend as a mirror — someone who reflects honestly rather than merely reflecting back what one
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	wants to see.
Content	Loyalty, honesty in the difficult moment, showing up when it costs something, the courage to say the hard thing. The friend who tells you what you want to hear vs. the one who tells you what you need. The difference between pleasant company and genuine friendship.
Approach & Methods	Friendship case studies, class norms building, reflection on their best friendship. Teacher shares what their closest friend taught them about themselves.
Teaching Principles	The friend as mirror. Real friendship involves honest reflection — not mere positive reinforcement. This concept — that the most valuable thing a friend can offer is honest perception — is one that must be introduced carefully and gradually. It is more demanding than the concept of friendship as enjoyment.
Formation Ground	Aristotle's three types of friendship — based on pleasure, on utility, and on genuine care for the other's character (what he calls 'perfect friendship') — remain the most useful analytical framework available. The third kind — where each person genuinely wants the other to flourish and says what is true rather than what is pleasant — is both the rarest and the most formative. The question for each student is not just 'do I have friends?' but 'are my friendships of the kind that make me better?'

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can name three qualities of genuine friendship and apply them to evaluate one of their friendships.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to examine whether their current friendships are raising or lowering them.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from friendship-as-enjoyment toward friendship-as-mutual-formation.

L08 Lesson 8: Gratitude Changes Everything

What would I be without everything I have been given?

Why This Topic	Gratitude deepened beyond social courtesy into genuine philosophical recognition: everything I have was given to me, and this recognition changes the fundamental orientation from which I encounter the world.
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Content	What I have that I did not earn: body, family, language, home, community, existence itself. The structure of gift-receiving and the response it calls for. Gratitude as a way of seeing the world — a perceptual orientation — not merely a feeling.
Approach & Methods	Gratitude letter to someone important, gratitude audit of their life, class discussion. Teacher writes and reads a genuine gratitude letter — not a performance.
Teaching Principles	Make the invisible visible. Gratitude requires learning to see what is already there. Most of what we have is invisible gift — which is why most of us walk through the world in a state of chronic unawareness of how much we have received.
Formation Ground	The philosopher Marcus Aurelius begins his Meditations with several pages of gratitude — specific, personal, concrete gratitude for what specific people gave him. Modern psychological research (Robert Emmons, Martin Seligman) confirms: sustained gratitude practice measurably increases wellbeing, generosity, moral perception, and the quality of relationships. But more fundamentally: the grateful person sees correctly. They see the gift behind the given, the receiver-status of the self. This accurate perception changes everything about how one inhabits the world.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can identify five things they are grateful for that they did not earn and explain why gratitude is a way of seeing rather than merely a feeling.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to notice the accumulated gift of their existence.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from taking existence for granted toward a habitual posture of genuine gratitude.

L09 Lesson 9: Stories That Shape Us

Who am I in the stories I love?

Why This Topic	The stories a child absorbs shape their moral imagination — their sense of who counts, what matters, what courage looks like, what love demands. Making this selection conscious is a formation act. The student who can see the values embedded in their favorite stories has begun to exercise genuine critical judgment.
Content	How stories teach values without feeling like lectures. The stories

	they know and love and what those stories communicate about good and evil, strength and weakness, honor and betrayal. The concept that stories are always doing formation work — the question is whether we notice.
Approach & Methods	Analysis of favorite stories through a values lens, sharing stories from multiple traditions, class story-writing. Teacher shares a story that genuinely formed them.
Teaching Principles	Honor the stories they already love. Critical analysis of narrative is a gift when it begins with genuine care for what the student already carries. Condemnation of popular stories closes the conversation; honest inquiry opens it.
Formation Ground	The philosopher Martha Nussbaum has argued that literary imagination — the capacity to inhabit the perspective of characters unlike oneself — is one of the foundational capacities of moral life. Without narrative, we cannot understand the experience of others. Without others' experience, we cannot develop genuine justice or compassion. The stories children choose are not merely entertainment — they are the raw material of moral imagination.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can analyze one of their favorite stories to identify the values it teaches and whether those values are the ones they want to be shaped by.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to see the formation work that stories are always doing on them.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from unconscious absorption of narrative values toward conscious engagement with what stories are forming in us.

L10 Lesson 10: Signs in the World

Does the world tell us anything — or is it silent?

Why This Topic	One of the most philosophically important lessons in the curriculum. The question of whether the natural world is merely a collection of mechanisms or whether it discloses something about the nature of reality is the deepest question of natural philosophy — and it arises naturally from genuine attention to the world's beauty and order.
Content	The design of natural phenomena — the eye, the ecosystem, the mathematical structure of snowflakes, the emergence of

	consciousness from matter — as occasions for the question: is this pointing at something? Philosophers, scientists, and poets across traditions have asked this question and given very different answers. The curriculum takes seriously the possibility that the answer is 'yes.'
Approach & Methods	Science-and-wonder integration, outdoor observation journal, readings from natural philosophy. Teacher models genuine awe at natural complexity.
Teaching Principles	Keep wonder central. The moment natural philosophy becomes argument rather than wonder, it has already lost. The goal is a student who looks at a leaf and genuinely wonders — not a student who has been told what conclusion to reach.
Formation Ground	The philosopher and scientist Michael Polanyi argued that tacit knowledge — the background of understanding from which all explicit knowledge emerges — points toward a 'participation' in reality that goes beyond mere mechanism. Einstein: 'The most incomprehensible thing about the universe is that it is comprehensible.' The philosopher Alvin Plantinga: 'The naturalist faces a nagging worry about how natural selection, aiming at survival rather than truth, could produce reliable cognitive faculties.' The question of what the world's intelligibility and beauty disclose is genuinely open, and the curriculum holds it as such.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain the difference between seeing the world as mere mechanism and seeing it as potentially disclosive, and give two examples of natural phenomena that make them wonder.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to look at natural phenomena and ask 'what does this point toward?' rather than merely 'how does this work?'
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from seeing nature as backdrop toward seeing it as potentially meaningful and worth attending to with philosophical seriousness.

GRADE 4 — Age 9–10

Authenticity, Responsibility, and What We Actually Worship

Grade 4 introduces the concept of the self as capable of falseness — of being untrue to its own nature. Peer pressure becomes a real formation force, and the curriculum engages it directly. The concept of stewardship is deepened: everything one has is held in trust. The concept of hidden attachments — what we are actually organized around vs. what we say we are organized around — begins the long arc toward one of the curriculum's most important formation themes.

L01 Lesson 1: The Self I Show vs. The Self I Am

Am I the same person in private that I am in public?

Why This Topic

Authenticity introduced as a genuine and urgent question. The gap between what we perform and who we actually are is one of the most significant formation problems of adolescence, and it begins here at Grade 4.

Content

The social self vs. the private self. The masks we wear. Why do we perform differently depending on who is watching? Which version is true? The concept that sustained performance is exhausting — and that the exhaustion itself is information.

Approach & Methods

Reflection journal, discussion of a time they acted differently because of who was watching. Teacher shares their own experience of performance vs. authenticity.

Teaching Principles

Name the gap without shame. Every person wears social masks — this is not the problem. The problem arises when the performance gradually replaces the reality — when the student can no longer locate themselves beneath the persona.

Formation Ground

The philosopher Charles Taylor argued that authenticity — being true to one's own original nature rather than merely conforming to external expectations — is one of the most important moral ideals of modern life. But authenticity requires knowing what one's original nature is. The student who has never looked beneath their social performances has no access to the authentic self that authenticity calls them to be.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual

Students can describe the difference between their public and private self and explain why consistency between them matters.

Reflective

This lesson creates conditions for students to notice the cost of sustained performance on their interior life.

Dispositional

Over time, this contributes to moving from performance-based

identity toward authentic consistency.

L02 Lesson 2: Peer Pressure: Who Do I Choose to Be?

How do other people change who I am?

Why This Topic

Social conformity as one of the most powerful formation forces in early adolescence. This lesson makes the mechanism visible so students can recognize it as it operates on them — the first step toward being able to act deliberately rather than automatically.

Content

How peer pressure works: the physical sensation of social disapproval, the neurological pull toward belonging, the cost of being different. The crucial insight: yielding to pressure is a choice, not an inevitability. And choices build character — in one direction or another.

Approach & Methods

Role-play scenarios with real social cost, class discussion of a time they caved and a time they held their position. Teacher shares their own peer pressure experiences.

Teaching Principles

Make the social force visible. Students cannot resist what they cannot see. Naming the mechanism is the first act of genuine agency in relation to it.

Formation Ground

The sociologist Erving Goffman described social life as theatrical performance — we present 'front stage' selves calibrated to what different audiences expect. This is not pathological; it is social. But the person who has no 'back stage' self — no private self that persists beneath the performances — is not free. They are infinitely malleable, which is the opposite of having character.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual

Students can describe how peer pressure works and identify one value they would hold even if others disapproved.

Reflective

This lesson creates conditions for students to notice peer pressure operating on them in real time.

Dispositional

Over time, this contributes to moving from automatic social conformity toward deliberate value-based choice.

L03 Lesson 3: Patience in Difficulty

Can patience be a strength rather than passivity?

Why This Topic	Patience deepened: not passive waiting but active perseverance — the capacity to hold one's orientation under pressure, to refuse to let difficulty determine one's direction. Three forms introduced: patience in sustained effort, patience with difficult people, patience with oneself in failure.
Content	The difference between passive resignation and active endurance. Real examples from history of people who held their position under extraordinary pressure. The concept that the difficulty is sometimes the point — that the growth happens precisely in the endurance.
Approach & Methods	Personal challenge stories, historical case studies of sustained endurance, class discussion. Teacher shares a sustained difficulty they endured and what it required of them.
Teaching Principles	Active patience. The person of genuine patience is not passive — they are holding ground. The Stoic image is apt: the tree that bends in the storm but does not break, because its roots go deeper than the storm can reach.
Formation Ground	The Stoics — particularly Epictetus, who was born into slavery — developed the most rigorous account of patient endurance in the philosophical tradition. Their core insight: we cannot control what happens to us, but we can always control our response. The person who has developed this capacity is genuinely free, regardless of external circumstances. Angela Duckworth's grit research confirms: the capacity to persist through difficulty is among the strongest predictors of long-term achievement and flourishing.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can distinguish active patience from passive resignation and describe one situation where they need it.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to experience the inner sense of active holding rather than passive waiting.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from giving up or passive endurance toward active, oriented perseverance.

L04 Lesson 4: What Is Justice?

Can there be justice without truth?

Why This Topic	Justice elevated from 'fair treatment' to a genuine philosophical concept: seeing clearly, speaking honestly, and responding proportionately. The three elements can fail independently — one can see clearly and still speak dishonestly; one can speak honestly and still respond disproportionately.
Content	Justice as requiring three distinct things that can fail independently: seeing clearly (what actually happened), speaking honestly (what it means), responding proportionately (what it requires). Case studies of justice failures at each level.
Approach & Methods	Justice case studies, deliberation on challenging scenarios, teacher presents a case with no clean resolution.
Teaching Principles	Discomfort is pedagogical. A justice dilemma with a clean answer is not doing its job. The formation value lies in the experience of sitting with genuine difficulty and still being required to act.
Formation Ground	Aristotle's account of justice as 'giving to each what they are owed' — proportionate to their situation — remains foundational. John Rawls added the 'veil of ignorance' test: a just arrangement is one you would accept if you did not know what position you would occupy within it. Both accounts share the insight that justice requires a specific quality of perception — seeing through one's own interests to what is actually required — that can be cultivated or neglected.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain justice as more than equal treatment and apply the three dimensions (seeing, speaking, responding) to a real case.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to feel the inadequacy of simplistic fairness in complex situations.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from simplistic rule-application toward genuine moral perception.

L05 Lesson 5: Being Responsible: The Trust We Carry

What have I been given that is not really mine?

Why This Topic	Stewardship deepened to encompass the full range of what one holds: body, mind, relationships, knowledge, time, talent. The shift from ownership to stewardship is one of the most fundamental moral orientation shifts available — it changes everything about how one inhabits what one has.
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Content	The concept of stewardship applied systematically: body, relationships, knowledge, environment, time. What am I doing with what I have been given? The concept that every gift carries an implicit responsibility for its use.
Approach & Methods	Stewardship audit, stories of people who used their gifts well vs. those who wasted them. Teacher shares a responsibility they are working to discharge well.
Teaching Principles	From ownership to stewardship. 'This is mine' is the ego's position. 'This is entrusted to me' is the character's position. The shift between these is a fundamental change in how one inhabits the world — and it cannot be made by instruction alone; it requires the repeated experience of actually choosing the steward's response.
Formation Ground	The philosopher Aldo Leopold's concept of the 'land ethic' extended stewardship to the natural world. The philosopher Hans Jonas argued that the capacity for responsibility — the recognition that what one has and does affects others — is the foundational moral fact about human existence. Modern philosophers from Peter Singer to Martha Nussbaum have developed the implications: with capacity comes responsibility. The more one has, the more one is answerable for.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain the concept of stewardship and identify three things in their life that are trusts, not possessions.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to feel the difference between ownership and stewardship.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from an ownership orientation toward a stewardship orientation toward life.

L06 Lesson 6: Learning from Failure

What does failure have to teach me?

Why This Topic	The relationship with failure is one of the most consequential formation choices available. A shame-based relationship with failure produces concealment, rigidity, and avoidance of genuine challenge. A learning-based relationship produces growth, resilience, and the willingness to take genuine risks.
Content	Failure as information rather than identity. Historical examples of people whose most significant failures were the turning point of their development. The neurological truth: the brain builds new

	connections specifically through the experience of not-yet-knowing and trying again.
Approach & Methods	Failure story sharing (teacher goes first, genuinely), biographical study of someone whose failure shaped their greatness. Teacher models the inquiry stance toward their own failures.
Teaching Principles	Normalize failure before celebrating resilience. The student who is ashamed of failure cannot learn from it. The curriculum must make failure safe — not comfortable, but safe — before it can be useful.
Formation Ground	Carol Dweck's research on fixed vs. growth mindset has confirmed empirically what the philosophical tradition knew: the interpretation one places on failure determines its developmental consequences. The person who treats failure as evidence of fixed inadequacy cannot develop. The person who treats failure as information about what to try differently can. This is not optimism — it is accurate perception of how development actually works.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can describe failure as information rather than identity and identify one lesson from a recent failure.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to approach their own failures with curiosity rather than shame.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from shame-based concealment of failure toward genuine learning from it.

L07 Lesson 7: What Do We Actually Organize Our Lives Around?

Is it possible to be devoted to something without knowing it?

Why This Topic	The concept of functional devotion: whatever one is actually organized around — whatever one fears losing most, loves most, and will compromise anything for — is functioning as one's ultimate concern, regardless of what one says one values. Making this visible is one of the most important formation acts available.
Content	The concept of functional ultimate concern: what you organize your life around, what you cannot imagine losing, what you will compromise anything for. The philosopher Paul Tillich's concept of 'ultimate concern' — what one is ultimately devoted to — as distinct from what one says one cares about. The diagnostic: what do you lose your peace about when you think about losing it?

Approach & Methods	'What would I give anything for?' discussion, stories of characters who sacrifice everything for something and examination of whether it was worth it. Teacher reflects on their own functional devotions honestly.
Teaching Principles	Expand the concept of devotion. If students only conceive of devotion in religious terms, they will never identify their actual devotions. The curriculum must widen the frame: everyone is devoted to something. The question is whether what one is devoted to is worth the devotion.
Formation Ground	The philosopher Paul Tillich argued that every human being has an 'ultimate concern' — something that functions as the ground and meaning of their life. Whatever this is, it is their functional 'god' — the organizing center of their existence. The theologian David Foster Wallace made the same point in secular terms: 'In the day-to-day trenches of adult life, there is actually no such thing as atheism. There is no such thing as not worshipping. Everybody worships. The only choice we get is what to worship.' This lesson makes that choice visible.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain the concept of functional ultimate concern and identify one thing they are actually organized around.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to notice what they are functionally devoted to rather than merely what they say they value.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from unconscious devotion to functional idols toward conscious examination and reorientation.

L08 Lesson 8: The Power of Words

Can words do damage that physical force cannot?

Why This Topic	Speech ethics introduced systematically: the word as a moral act, the durability of verbal harm, and the formative power of language on both the speaker and the recipient.
Content	What words do: they build, destroy, reveal, conceal, heal, and wound. The categories of speech that harm: gossip, slander, insult, false flattery. How words affect the person who speaks them, not only the person who receives them. The concept of thinking before speaking as a genuine virtue.
Approach & Methods	Word impact exercise (anonymized written experiences of words that stayed), discussion. Teacher shares the power of a specific word in

	their own life.
Teaching Principles	Honor the wound. Students know words hurt. Acknowledging the real damage before offering the moral framework is both more honest and more effective than jumping to prescription.
Formation Ground	The philosopher J.L. Austin's speech act theory demonstrated that words are not merely descriptions of reality — they are actions that change reality. To name, to promise, to accuse, to praise — these are acts with real consequences in the world. The Stoic tradition added: the words one chooses train the mind that chooses them. Every act of gossip makes the gossip a more gossipy person. Every act of honest speech makes the speaker a more honest person. Speech is self-formation.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can identify three categories of harmful speech and explain why words can cause more lasting damage than physical harm.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to become aware of the effect of their words on others and on themselves.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from careless speech toward deliberate, truth-aligned use of language.

L09 Lesson 9: Why Does Evil Exist?

If reality is ultimately good, why is the world sometimes terrible?

Why This Topic	The problem of evil — one of the most serious philosophical and existential questions available — is introduced here with appropriate developmental depth. Not with a formula, but with honest engagement: this is a genuinely difficult question, and the curriculum holds it as such.
Content	Suffering as real and not to be minimized. Different kinds: natural, human-caused, and genuinely mysterious. Simple frameworks: suffering as consequence of freedom, suffering as the forge of formation, suffering as genuine mystery. The concept of trust in the face of what cannot be fully explained.
Approach & Methods	Stories of people who found meaning in suffering, class discussion on the hardest things they have experienced. Teacher shares a difficulty that became a gift — and another that remains unexplained.

Teaching Principles	Take the question seriously. A child who asks this question deserves genuine engagement, not a formula. The student who senses that the answer is a dodge will not forget — and will return to the question without the resources the curriculum could have provided.
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Formation Ground	The philosopher Alvin Plantinga's 'free will defense' — that genuine freedom requires the real possibility of genuine evil — is the most widely discussed philosophical response. The philosopher Marilyn McCord Adams addresses 'horrendous evils' that seem to exceed any possible justification. The existentialist tradition (Camus, Sartre) argues that the honest response to genuine evil is neither theodicy nor despair but the embrace of what is within one's power. The curriculum holds these responses as genuine options rather than forcing a conclusion.
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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can name three ways that thoughtful people have approached the problem of evil and explain why the question remains genuinely difficult.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to hold the question of evil honestly rather than deflecting it.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from naive answers or cynical dismissal toward the kind of trust that holds through genuine difficulty.

L10 Lesson 10: Body and Soul

Am I just my body — or is there something more to me?

Why This Topic	The question of the self's nature — whether consciousness is reducible to the physical or whether there is something more — introduced experientially through the question of what the self actually is when you look closely.
Content	The body as real and important. Consciousness — the bare fact that there is something it is like to be you — as genuinely mysterious. The question: if you lost your body but kept your memories and loves, would you still be you? The concept that this question has been taken seriously by the greatest minds in human history.
Approach & Methods	Thought experiment on identity and consciousness, class discussion on the experience of being more than a body. Teacher models genuine philosophical wonder.

Teaching Principles	The question before the answer. Let the experience of interiority be its own evidence before offering any framework. The student who has genuinely wondered about their own consciousness has encountered one of the deepest mysteries available to a human being.
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Formation Ground	The philosopher David Chalmers calls consciousness 'the hard problem': why is there something it is like to be you, rather than merely physical processes happening? The philosopher Thomas Nagel's 'What Is It Like to Be a Bat?' demonstrates that subjective experience cannot be reduced to objective description. The philosopher Avicenna (Ibn Sina) — whose 'Floating Man' argument will be encountered in Grade 9 — showed that one can be aware of one's own existence even while stripped of all sensory input. These are not merely religious questions. They are among the deepest questions in philosophy.
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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can describe the difference between the body and consciousness and explain why the question of what the self is remains genuinely open.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to experience their own consciousness as genuinely mysterious rather than obviously explained.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from an unconscious materialist assumption toward genuine openness to the non-physical dimension of the self.

GRADE 5 — Age 10–11

Values, Desire, Technology, and the Question of Knowledge

Grade 5 marks a critical transition. Students are approaching adolescence and social pressures intensify sharply. The curriculum introduces the question of knowledge itself — where does genuine knowledge come from and what is it for? The critique of the reduction of knowledge to technical power appears for the first time. The first explicit philosophical engagement with the existence of an ultimate ground of reality appears. Digital formation receives its first systematic analysis.

L01 Lesson 1: My Identity Map

How many versions of me are there — and which is real?

Why This Topic

Identity is layered and complex — not a single fixed thing but a set of concentric circles, some more central and some more peripheral. The student who can map the layers of their own selfhood can navigate the developmental pressures of adolescence with genuine choice rather than automatic reaction.

Content

Mapping the layers: body, personality, roles, values, beliefs, and the deepest self — the original nature beneath all the social overlays. Understanding that some layers are more changeable and some more essential. The concept that the deepest layer is worth discovering.

Approach & Methods

Identity mapping activity (concentric circles from surface to center), class sharing, discussion on which layers feel most genuinely them. Teacher shares their own identity map honestly.

Teaching Principles

Layer before locating. Before a student can know who they are, they need a model of the self's structure. This map provides the scaffold for the formation work of the next seven years.

Formation Ground

The philosopher Paul Ricoeur distinguished between 'idem-identity' (the sameness of the self across time — the fact that it is me at six and me at sixteen) and 'ipse-identity' (the self-constancy of the person who keeps their promises and holds their values). The formation arc of the curriculum is the development of ipse-identity — not the rigid sameness of a fixed self but the self-constancy of a person who knows what they stand for.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual

Students can draw a concentric-circle identity map and explain which layers are most central to who they are.

Reflective

This lesson creates conditions for students to locate the deepest layer of themselves beneath the social accumulation.

Dispositional

Over time, this contributes to moving from surface-level identity

	toward awareness of the authentic self.
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L02 Lesson 2: The Courage to Disagree

Can I hold a position against social pressure?

Why This Topic

Moral courage at the specific point of disagreement. This is the form of courage most urgently needed in early adolescence — the capacity to hold one's genuine position against the social pressure to abandon it.

Content

The social cost of genuine disagreement. Why we agree when we don't believe it. The difference between respect and agreement. Famous examples of principled disagreement at genuine cost. The concept that the capacity to disagree respectfully is one of the marks of genuine character.

Approach & Methods

Scenario-based role-plays with real social cost, historical examples, teacher shares a genuine disagreement they held against social pressure.

Teaching Principles

Honor the cost. Disagreement with social pressure is one of the most costly things a ten-year-old can be asked to do. Acknowledging this before asking for it is the only honest pedagogical approach.

Formation Ground

The Stoic philosopher Epictetus — who spent his early life as a slave — developed the most radical account of inner freedom available: the person who has genuinely separated what is 'up to them' (their judgments, choices, responses) from what is not (others' opinions, social approval, external events) cannot be coerced into agreement by anyone. The philosopher Hannah Arendt: 'The most difficult thing in the world is to think for oneself.' The curriculum is developing exactly this capacity.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual

Students can distinguish between disagreement and disrespect and describe one situation where they held a position despite social pressure.

Reflective

This lesson creates conditions for students to notice the physical sensation of social disapproval and choose their response to it.

Dispositional

Over time, this contributes to moving from automatic social agreement toward the capacity to hold a genuine position.

L03 Lesson 3: Where Do My Values Come From?

Did I choose what I believe — or did it choose me?

Why This Topic	Values formation made conscious. Students discover that most of their values were absorbed rather than chosen — this is not necessarily bad, but it is worth examining. The difference between inherited values and examined values is the difference between borrowed identity and genuine character.
Content	Values audit: what do I think is important, and where did that idea come from? Family, culture, media, peer group, experience. The concept that conscious ownership of one's values is more stable than unreflective inheritance.
Approach & Methods	Values source-mapping activity, discussion. Teacher maps their own values origins honestly.
Teaching Principles	Examine without condemning. Inherited values are not automatically wrong — the question is whether one holds them consciously or merely by default. 'I hold this because I have examined it and found it true' is more stable under pressure than 'I hold this because I was told to.'
Formation Ground	The philosopher Socrates spent his life doing this work — examining whether the values his society inherited from tradition were actually worth holding. The Enlightenment philosopher Immanuel Kant: 'Have the courage to use your own understanding.' The psychologist Robert Kegan calls the transition from 'socialized mind' (values defined by others) to 'self-authoring mind' (values defined by oneself) the central developmental challenge of adolescence and young adulthood. This lesson plants the seed of that transition.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can create a values-source map and identify two values they have genuinely examined vs. two they hold by inheritance.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to ask 'is this mine because I've examined it, or just because I inherited it?'
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from unreflective cultural inheritance toward conscious, examined value-ownership.

L04 Lesson 4: Envy and Contentment

Why does what others have make me feel bad about what I have?

Why This Topic	Envy — the pain at another's good — is one of the most destructive and most normalized emotions in contemporary culture, structurally amplified by social media. Early, honest formation around it is genuinely urgent.
Content	The structure of envy: what triggers it, what it does to the interior, its distinction from healthy admiration or aspiration. The concept that envy is a form of objecting to how reality has distributed its gifts — and that this objection has costs.
Approach & Methods	Honest sharing circle about envy experiences, analysis of social media's envy machinery, exploration of contentment practices. Teacher shares their own history with envy.
Teaching Principles	Name the shame. Envy is deeply shameful to admit. Creating safety for honest disclosure before offering any framework is the only approach that reaches the actual problem.
Formation Ground	Aristotle identified envy as a vice — but he was precise about what kind: it is the pain felt at another's good fortune, regardless of whether that fortune diminishes one's own. Contrast with what the Greeks called 'emulation' — the desire to achieve something similar — which Aristotle considered a legitimate motivational response. The Stoics offered the most rigorous antidote: since external goods are not truly good (only virtue is genuinely good), their possession by others cannot genuinely harm one.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain the mechanism of envy and describe the difference between envy and healthy aspiration.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to recognize envy when it arises without being shamed by it.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from chronic comparison and envy toward genuine contentment with one's own gifts.

L05 Lesson 5: What Is a Good Life?

What do I want my life to actually be about?

Why This Topic	Telos — the concept of a life's purpose and direction — introduced through the concrete question: what matters, and why? This question,
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	planted at age ten, will grow across the next eight years of the curriculum.
Content	Different models of the good life: pleasure, achievement, fame, service, excellence, love, meaning. Examples of each. Discussion of what they actually want their own life to be about — not what they think they should say, but what they genuinely want.
Approach & Methods	Life vision letter (to their future self), exemplar study of people who lived purposefully. Teacher shares their own sense of what their life is for.
Teaching Principles	Plant the question early. The question of what life is for, asked at ten with genuine seriousness, will grow across the next eight years. The goal is not an answer but a sustained inquiry.
Formation Ground	Aristotle's concept of eudaimonia — often translated as 'happiness' but better understood as 'flourishing' or 'living well and doing well' — is the organizing concept of his entire ethics. For Aristotle, the good life is not the pleasant life or the successful life or the moral life alone, but the life in which one actuates one's highest capacities in the context of genuine community. The contemporary philosopher Susan Wolf adds: a meaningful life requires both subjective engagement and objective worth — what she calls 'active engagement in projects of worth.'

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can describe three different models of the good life and articulate what they currently think their life is for.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to take the question of life's purpose seriously for the first time.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from living by default toward living with a sense of direction and meaning.

L06 Lesson 6: Technology and Me

Is my device shaping who I am — and do I have a say in that?

Why This Topic	Digital formation: the explicit analysis of what digital environments do to attention, identity, desire, and the capacity for genuine relationship. This is one of the most urgent lessons in the curriculum — and must be approached with genuine inquiry rather than moralizing.
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Content	How algorithms work and what they are actually designed to produce: not wellbeing but engagement. The attention economy's design goals. What constant stimulation does to the capacity for silence, depth, presence, and genuine relationship. The concept that the device is not neutral — it has a design intention.
Approach & Methods	Device-free day reflection, algorithm audit ('what does my feed tell me about me?'), class discussion. Teacher shares their own digital formation struggles honestly.
Teaching Principles	Honest before prescriptive. Begin with genuine inquiry: what does it actually do to you? Let students diagnose before offering any framework. Students who are lectured about screens disengage; students who are helped to see the mechanism become its analysts.
Formation Ground	The philosopher Albert Borgmann's concept of 'device paradigm' — the way modern devices conceal their mechanism while delivering commodified goods that replace genuine engagement with reality — applies directly to digital platforms. Borgmann: 'Things engage us in their fullness, but devices replace this engagement with mere consumption.' Jonathan Haidt's research on social media and adolescent mental health confirms what the philosophical tradition anticipated: the replacement of genuine engagement with mediated consumption has measurable costs.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain how algorithms work and describe two specific effects that digital consumption has had on their own attention or mood.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to see the design goals of digital platforms rather than simply being subject to them.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from unconscious digital consumption toward deliberate, limited, authentic engagement.

L07 Lesson 7: Justice and Mercy: When They Conflict

Is it possible to be both just and merciful?

Why This Topic	The tension between two cardinal virtues: can you give someone what they deserve and still show genuine mercy? This is one of the deepest tensions in ethical reasoning and one the curriculum holds rather than resolves prematurely.
Content	Real cases where justice and mercy appear to conflict. The concept of

	mitigating circumstances. Historical examples of figures who held both together under genuine pressure. The concept that the highest moral achievement holds both rather than choosing between them.
Approach & Methods	Case study discussions, role-play of a judge's dilemma, reading a philosophical account that holds both. Teacher presents a real situation from their own life.
Teaching Principles	Both are real. Students often assume justice and mercy are opposites. The curriculum holds the tension and asks: is there a way to honor both that sacrifices neither? The experience of sitting with this tension is more formative than any answer.
Formation Ground	The philosopher Hannah Arendt argued that forgiveness — the willingness to release someone from the full consequences of what they have done — is one of the most distinctively human capacities, because it breaks the mechanical causal chain of action-consequence. Without forgiveness, the past imprisons the future. But without justice, the wrong is not acknowledged and the victim's reality is denied. The greatest moral traditions hold both — and the tension between them is not resolved by eliminating one.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can describe a situation where justice and mercy are in tension and propose a resolution that honors both.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to feel the genuine difficulty of holding justice and mercy simultaneously.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from binary thinking (just or merciful) toward the integrated judgment that holds both.

L08 Lesson 8: The Heart's Condition

Can the self be healthy or sick — and how would I know?

Why This Topic	The interior life introduced as having conditions that can be diagnosed and treated — not in the medical sense but in the philosophical and psychological sense. The concept that the self's perceptual and motivational organ can be more or less healthy, more or less clear, and that this makes an enormous practical difference.
Content	What makes the interior life healthy: genuine relationship, honest self-examination, beauty, service, silence. What clouds it: distraction, envy, resentment, dishonesty, isolation. The symptoms of a clouded interior vs. a clear one.

Approach & Methods	Interior condition reflection (honest self-assessment), discussion of things that help and things that cloud. Teacher shares their own practices for interior health.
Teaching Principles	Experience before diagnosis. 'When do you feel most yourself?' is a better entry point than any technical vocabulary. Let students identify the states before giving them the names.
Formation Ground	The philosopher Al-Ghazali (11th c.) developed the most systematic account of the heart's conditions and their remedies in his <i>Revival of the Religious Sciences</i> — a work that influenced Christian, Jewish, and secular thinkers as well as Muslim ones. Modern positive psychology (Seligman, Csikszentmihalyi) has developed empirical accounts of the conditions that produce psychological flourishing that parallel the classical account in striking ways. The convergence is not coincidental: both are observing the same reality.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can identify two things that support their interior health and two things that cloud it, and explain why this matters.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to begin monitoring the condition of their interior life as something real and important.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from unawareness of interior states toward ongoing attentiveness to the quality of one's inner life.

L09 Lesson 9: What Is Attention For?

Am I present when I pray — or practice — or am I somewhere else?

Why This Topic	The question of genuine presence — whether in prayer, in relationship, in study, in any practice requiring sustained attention — introduced as one of the most practically important formation questions available.
Content	The gap between going through the motions and being genuinely present. What genuine presence makes possible that divided attention cannot. The concept that any serious practice — whether prayer, meditation, contemplation, or simply reading — requires the quality of attention called presence.
Approach & Methods	Contemplative preparation for a single brief practice of genuine presence, reflection on the last time they were fully present in something. Teacher shares their own struggle with presence.

Teaching Principles	Honest about the difficulty. Students who are told that presence should be easy but find it hard feel ashamed and confused. Name the difficulty before offering any path through it.
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Formation Ground	The philosopher Simone Weil: 'Attention is the rarest and purest form of generosity.' William James, the philosopher and psychologist: 'The faculty of voluntarily bringing back a wandering attention, over and over again, is the very root of judgment, character, and will.' The philosopher Iris Murdoch: genuine attention to what is really there — rather than the ego's projections onto it — is the foundational moral act. All three point at the same insight: the quality of one's attention is the quality of one's life.
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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain the concept of genuine presence and identify one obstacle to their own presence in practices they care about.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to notice the difference between present engagement and going through the motions.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from distracted, performative engagement toward the development of genuine interior presence.

L10 Lesson 10: Is There an Ultimate Ground?

How would I argue for the existence of something beyond the material — and why does it matter?

Why This Topic	The first explicit philosophical engagement with the question of whether there is an ultimate ground of reality. Not a religious claim requiring assent but a genuine philosophical question that the greatest minds have grappled with.
Content	Three approaches: cosmological (why is there something rather than nothing?), teleological (why is the world ordered toward intelligibility and beauty?), and experiential (why does consciousness seem to point beyond itself?). The concept that serious engagement with this question is a mark of intellectual maturity, not naivety.
Approach & Methods	Philosophical discussion scaffolded with Socratic questions, students construct their own preliminary arguments. Teacher models genuine intellectual engagement.
Teaching Principles	Confidence through inquiry. The student who has thought seriously about these questions is more stable in whatever position they hold than the one who has never questioned. Inquiry is not a threat to

	conviction — it is its foundation.
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Formation Ground	Leibniz asked 'why is there something rather than nothing?' — and argued that the answer must appeal to a 'sufficient reason' that itself requires no further reason, which he identified with God. The philosopher Richard Swinburne has developed a rigorous probabilistic argument for theism as the simplest explanation of the universe's existence and order. The philosopher Alvin Plantinga has argued that belief in God is 'properly basic' — not requiring argument the way one's belief in the external world does not. These are serious philosophical positions, not mere religious assertions.
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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can articulate two philosophical arguments for an ultimate ground of reality and explain why the question matters for how one lives.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to think seriously about the most fundamental question of existence.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from inherited religious belief or inherited atheism toward examined, personally owned conviction.

GRADE 6 — Age 11–12

Transition, the Self's Layers, and Three Ways of Knowing

Grade 6 marks the transition to middle school and a major developmental threshold. The three modes of genuine knowledge — transmitted learning, rational inquiry, and direct experiential recognition — are introduced explicitly as a framework that will govern all subsequent epistemological work. The Socratic method is now used regularly. The concept of the reactive self — the self that automatically pursues immediate gratification — is named and engaged rather than suppressed.

L01 Lesson 1: Who Am I Becoming?

Am I in charge of who I'm turning into — or is something else?

Why This Topic

The developmental transition is honored explicitly. Students are told: this is one of the most important periods of your life for character. Are you choosing who you are becoming — or is your environment choosing it for you?

Content

The concept of deliberate formation: we are always being shaped by something, and the question is whether that shaping is conscious or automatic. The forces currently shaping them — peer culture, digital environment, family — named and examined.

Approach & Methods

Formation audit (what is shaping me right now?), class discussion. Teacher maps their own formation history.

Teaching Principles

Name the moment. Students who know they are at a developmental threshold engage with formation work more seriously. The developmental fact is formation-relevant: adolescence is the period of greatest plasticity and greatest vulnerability simultaneously.

Formation Ground

The psychologist Robert Kegan describes the transition from 'socialized mind' (self defined by others' expectations) to 'self-authoring mind' (self defined by one's own internalized values) as the central developmental challenge of adolescence and young adulthood. Most people, he finds, never complete this transition. The curriculum is designed to support it.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual

Students can identify three forces currently shaping their character and explain which they want to influence deliberately.

Reflective

This lesson creates conditions for students to feel genuine agency over their own formation.

Dispositional

Over time, this contributes to moving from passive formation by default toward deliberate self-authorship.

L02 Lesson 2: The Reactive Self and Its Patterns

Why do I want things I know are bad for me?

Why This Topic	The concept of the reactive self — the part of us that automatically pursues immediate gratification, social approval, and the avoidance of discomfort — introduced by name. This is one of the most liberating formation concepts available: the recognition that this reactive pattern is not who we are at our deepest level, but a force within us that can be observed and engaged.
Content	The reactive self as a pattern with its own momentum — not who I am, but a force within me. Three stages of the self's development introduced: reactive (automatically pursuing gratification), reflective (capable of self-observation), integrated (genuinely at rest in its own values). The possibility of movement between these stages.
Approach & Methods	Personal examples of reactive patterns, philosophical storytelling about the structure of the self, class discussion. Teacher shares their own experience of the reactive self honestly.
Teaching Principles	Name the pattern without condemning the person. The student who understands that the reactive self is not their truest self is freed from shame while being equipped for genuine engagement with the pattern.
Formation Ground	Plato's account of the soul's parts — appetite, spirit, and reason — is the foundational philosophical description of the reactive self. Freud rediscovered the same structure in the id, ego, and superego. Modern neuroscience distinguishes the limbic system's reactive responses from the prefrontal cortex's deliberative ones. The philosopher Frankfurt distinguished 'first-order desires' (wanting what one wants) from 'second-order desires' (wanting to want differently). All point at the same insight: the self has levels, and character formation is the work of the higher levels governing the lower.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can name the three stages of the self's development and explain which stage they are primarily in and why.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to experience the reactive self as a pattern within them rather than as who they are.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from identification with the reactive self toward the capacity to observe it and choose differently.

L03 Lesson 3: Digital Identity: Who Am I Online?

Who am I on social media — and is that me?

Why This Topic	Digital identity examined at depth: the curated self, the comparison machinery, and the epistemological damage that sustained performance does to genuine self-knowledge.
Content	The platform's design goal (engagement through emotional activation). The gap between the person one is and the person one performs online. The social comparison loops and their psychological effects. What sustained self-curation does to the authentic self.
Approach & Methods	Feed audit, persona analysis, design exercise on what healthy digital identity would look like. Teacher shares their own digital formation journey.
Teaching Principles	Diagnose before prescribing. Students helped to see the mechanism become analysts of it. Students lectured disengage immediately.
Formation Ground	The sociologist Erving Goffman's concept of 'impression management' — the deliberate management of one's presentation to different audiences — was developed before the internet. Social media has industrialized and monetized impression management in ways Goffman could not have anticipated. The philosopher Albert Borgmann's concept of 'device paradigm' explains why: the platform replaces genuine engagement with mediated performance, delivering the appearance of connection while hollowing out its reality.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain how social media platforms use algorithms to shape behavior and identify two ways their feed has shaped their self-image.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to see the design goals of digital platforms rather than simply being subject to them.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from unconscious digital performance toward deliberate, limited, authentic engagement.

L04 Lesson 4: What Is 'Cool' — And Who Decided?

Who designed what I want to be?

Why This Topic	Cultural values analysis: 'cool' as a set of norms created by market forces and peer dynamics, not by moral reasoning. Making the
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	construction visible is itself a liberation — you cannot resist what you cannot see.
Content	Where ideas of 'cool' come from, who benefits from them, what they cost. The concept of manufactured desire: wants that were designed rather than discovered. How coolness standards change across time, culture, and peer group — evidence that they are constructed, not natural.
Approach & Methods	Historical analysis of coolness norms, class deconstruction of current standards, discussion of what they would choose if no one were watching. Teacher reflects on their generation's 'cool' and its costs.
Teaching Principles	Expose the construction. Most students have never been told that what is 'cool' was designed. The revelation that it is manufactured — and that someone profits from their conformity — is genuinely liberating.
Formation Ground	The Frankfurt School philosophers (Adorno, Horkheimer) argued that consumer culture manufactures desires rather than merely satisfying them — that the 'culture industry' produces standardized products while giving the illusion of choice and authenticity. This is the philosophical framework behind the observation that 'cool' is not naturally occurring but commercially produced.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can trace the origins of two current 'cool' standards and identify who benefits from those standards.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to see their desire to be 'cool' as manufactured rather than natural.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from conforming to manufactured standards toward evaluating standards by one's own examined values.

L05 Lesson 5: Honest With Myself

Am I telling myself the truth?

Why This Topic	Self-deception introduced as a common, serious, and structurally understandable phenomenon. The capacity to lie to oneself is one of the most important and least acknowledged realities in moral formation — it corrupts the very instrument through which all other formation work must pass.
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Content	How self-deception works: motivated reasoning, rationalization, selective attention, the stories we tell to justify what we wanted to do anyway. The gap between the story we tell ourselves and what is actually happening.
Approach & Methods	Rationalization case studies, honest reflection journal. Teacher shares a self-deception they have genuinely recognized and moved through.
Teaching Principles	Hold the mirror gently. Self-deception is embarrassing to admit. Creating safety for genuine honest self-examination before asking for it is the only approach that works.
Formation Ground	The philosopher Jean-Paul Sartre called self-deception 'bad faith' (mauvaise foi) — the refusal to acknowledge one's own freedom and responsibility by pretending that one's choices are determined by external forces. The psychologist Daniel Kahneman's research distinguishes System 1 (fast, automatic, often self-serving reasoning) from System 2 (slow, deliberate, more honest reasoning): the self-deceiver uses System 1 to generate a conclusion they want and System 2 to construct a seemingly rational justification for it.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain how rationalization works and identify one recent example of telling themselves a story that wasn't quite true.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to catch themselves mid-rationalization.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from automatic self-justification toward honest self-assessment.

L06 Lesson 6: Do I Believe What I Say I Believe?

What is the gap between my stated values and how I actually live?

Why This Topic	The concept of operational belief vs. stated belief — what one says one believes vs. what one's life reveals one actually believes. This is one of the most important diagnostic questions in the curriculum, and it requires genuine safety to engage honestly.
Content	The concept of functional belief: the belief that governs actual behavior, regardless of what one says. If I say I value honesty but lie when it's convenient, what do I actually believe about honesty? The gap between stated values and lived values as the central formation diagnostic.

Approach & Methods	Belief-behavior mapping (anonymized), honest class discussion. Teacher shares their own belief-practice gap.
Teaching Principles	Respect the honesty. Students who admit 'I say I believe X but live like I don't' are doing extraordinary self-knowledge work. Celebrate the honesty before addressing the gap.
Formation Ground	The philosopher William James distinguished between 'live' and 'dead' hypotheses: a live hypothesis is one that actually makes a difference to how one acts; a dead hypothesis is one that is merely stated. Most people have many stated beliefs that are, in practice, dead hypotheses. The formation task is to move beliefs from dead to live — from merely stated to genuinely operative.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can identify one belief they genuinely act on and one they say they hold but don't yet live by.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to notice the gap between stated and operational belief without shame.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from professing beliefs without living them toward genuinely embodied conviction.

L07 Lesson 7: Anger and Its Wisdom

What is my anger actually telling me?

Why This Topic	Anger reframed: not a problem to be eliminated but information about violated values. The question is not whether to feel angry but what to do with what the anger is pointing at.
Content	Anger as a signal of violated value: what does my anger tell me I actually care about? The spectrum from suppression (which poisons the interior) to explosion (which harms others), and the deliberate middle path of informed, proportionate response.
Approach & Methods	Anger mapping (what triggered it, what value was violated), Aristotle's account of right anger. Teacher shares their own anger formation journey.
Teaching Principles	Legitimize before regulating. Anger that is simply suppressed has not been resolved — it has gone underground. The curriculum works with the anger rather than against it.

Formation Ground	Aristotle's account of anger is the most sophisticated available in the philosophical tradition: anger is not a vice. Feeling no anger at genuine injustice is a defect of moral perception. The virtue is feeling the right amount of anger, for the right reason, at the right person, at the right time — and responding appropriately. This is not easy. It is one of the marks of genuine character.
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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can identify the value that was violated when they last felt angry and describe one way to act from that anger wisely rather than reactively.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to use anger as information rather than simply reacting to it.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from reactive anger to responsive, value-based moral energy.

L08 Lesson 8: The Comparison Trap

Why does everyone else seem to have it better?

Why This Topic	The comparison trap in the digital age: the mechanism, the structural unfairness of the comparison, and the path toward genuine contentment — not as a consolation but as accurate perception.
Content	How comparison is structurally rigged: we compare our full interior experience with others' curated exterior presentation. The platform is designed to make this comparison maximally painful. The path toward contentment as genuine perception: knowing that one's own gifts are genuinely one's own.
Approach & Methods	Social comparison research shared accessibly, personal comparison audit. Teacher shares their own comparison struggles.
Teaching Principles	Diagnose the mechanism. Students who understand why comparison is structurally unfair can interrupt the automatic cycle.
Formation Ground	The philosopher Alain de Botton's 'Status Anxiety' traces the pathology of social comparison through the history of philosophy and art. The Stoic response: external goods — status, recognition, material wealth — are not genuinely good, only apparently good. Since they are not genuinely good, their possession by others cannot genuinely harm you. The philosopher Boethius, writing in prison awaiting execution: 'Fortune flatters you only to lure you into her trap. She is faithless to her friends and puts those she has enslaved at

	the service of those she controls.'
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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain why social comparison is structurally unfair and describe one practice that supports genuine contentment.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to interrupt the comparison loop by seeing its structural design.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from chronic comparison toward genuine contentment with one's own gifts and path.

L09 Lesson 9: What Makes Something Wrong?

Is something wrong because authority says so — or does authority say so because it's wrong?

Why This Topic	The Euthyphro dilemma introduced simply. This is one of the most important philosophical questions in ethical reasoning — and a frequent source of genuine intellectual confusion. Meeting it here prepares students for the deeper encounter in Grades 9 and 11.
Content	The question: is something wrong because an authority declares it wrong — or does the authority declare it wrong because it is genuinely wrong? What would it mean for morality to be arbitrary? What would it mean for it to be genuinely grounded?
Approach & Methods	Class discussion of a moral scenario, introduction of the Euthyphro question. Teacher engages with genuine philosophical interest.
Teaching Principles	Engage the question seriously. Students who sense a dodge will remain vulnerable to the confusion. Genuine philosophical engagement is more stabilizing than any formula.
Formation Ground	Plato's Euthyphro (c. 399 BCE) poses the question directly: is the pious thing pious because the gods love it, or do the gods love it because it is pious? The dilemma applies to any authority-based ethics. The natural law tradition (Aquinas, Grotius, Finnis) argues that moral facts are grounded in the nature of reality and human flourishing — which is why authority recognizes them rather than creating them. This is the position the curriculum implicitly takes.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can articulate the Euthyphro dilemma and explain the natural law response to it.
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Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to think about the relationship between authority and genuine moral truth.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from experiencing moral authority as arbitrary toward understanding ethics as grounded in the nature of reality.

L10 Lesson 10: Three Ways of Knowing

Can I know ultimate reality with my senses? My reason? My experience?

Why This Topic	One of the most important lessons in the entire curriculum. The three modes of genuine knowledge — transmitted learning, rational inquiry, and direct experiential recognition — are introduced explicitly as a framework that will govern all subsequent epistemological work.
Content	Transmitted knowledge: what has been reliably passed down through trustworthy traditions and witnesses. Rational knowledge: what the mind can reach through careful argument and inference. Experiential knowledge: what one knows through direct encounter — the knowledge of having been through something, tasted something, met something. Each is legitimate; each has its domain; none is sufficient alone.
Approach & Methods	Epistemology mapping activity, personal exploration of how they 'know' different things (love, beauty, mathematical truth, ultimate reality). Teacher shares their own epistemological journey.
Teaching Principles	Expand the model before making the case for any particular knowledge claim. The student trapped in an empiricist-only model of knowledge cannot access large portions of genuine human knowing. This lesson reopens the epistemological question.
Formation Ground	The philosopher Michael Polanyi distinguished between 'explicit knowledge' (what can be stated in propositions) and 'tacit knowledge' (what is known through skilled practice and direct engagement). The philosopher William James documented the full range of human knowing in his <i>Varieties of Religious Experience</i> . The philosopher Iris Murdoch insisted that genuine moral knowledge requires a specific quality of attentive experience — it cannot be reduced to propositional knowledge. Together, these point at a richer epistemology than the dominant empiricist model provides.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can define and give an example of each of the three modes of knowledge and explain why experiential knowledge requires different preparation than rational knowledge.
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Reflective

This lesson creates conditions for students to expand their concept of what counts as genuine knowledge.

Dispositional

Over time, this contributes to moving from an unconsciously empiricist epistemology toward an integrated model that includes all three modes of genuine knowing.

GRADE 7 — Age 12–13

Desire, Discipline, the Proper Place of Things, and Psychological Health

Grade 7 is one of the most critical years in the curriculum. The reactive self is at its most operationally dominant. The concept of adab — knowing the proper place and proper due of each thing one encounters — is introduced formally as the educational concept that underlies all genuine culture. The microcosm-macrocosm correspondence appears: the structure of the self mirrors the structure of the cosmos. Psychological health is addressed directly and without flinching.

L01 Lesson 1: The Masks I Wear

How many versions of myself have I created — and which is real?

Why This Topic

Persona analysis: the masks of social performance examined systematically. The diagnosis is not that social adaptation is wrong — contextual presentation is human and appropriate — but that the mask can gradually replace the face if genuine self-knowledge is not cultivated.

Content

Different masks for different contexts: school, home, friends, online, in practices one takes seriously. The exhaustion of sustained performance. What happens when masks are removed. The self that needs no audience.

Approach & Methods

Persona mapping, anonymous reflection. Teacher shares their own persona history with genuine honesty.

Teaching Principles

The mask is not the enemy. The problem arises when the mask becomes the face — when the student can no longer locate themselves beneath the performance. This is the pathology the curriculum is designed to prevent.

Formation Ground

The sociologist Erving Goffman's dramaturgical model of social life — everyone is always performing for audiences — is the most influential description of social persona in the social sciences. But Goffman himself acknowledged a 'backstage' self beneath the performances. The existentialist philosopher Sartre's concept of 'bad faith' captures what happens when the backstage self is denied: the person who has no genuine self behind the role has chosen not to be genuinely human.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual

Students can map the different personas they present and identify which one feels most genuinely them.

Reflective

This lesson creates conditions for students to notice the exhaustion of sustained performance.

Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from persona-management toward genuine, integrated selfhood.
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L02 Lesson 2: Desire and Discipline

How do I want things I don't want to want?

Why This Topic	The spiritual and philosophical discipline of engaging desire — not suppressing it and not indulging it, but working with it deliberately. The concept that the same desire, redirected, can become a strength.
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Content	The structure of temptation: how desires work, why they are stronger in some moments, the role of environment in amplifying them. The practice of deliberate delay and redirection. The concept that disciplined engagement with desire is more sustainable than willpower-based suppression.
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Approach & Methods	Personal desire mapping (what patterns are most persistent), practical strategies from multiple traditions. Teacher shares their own discipline practice honestly.
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Teaching Principles	Respect the struggle. Students told that desire is simply wrong will either suppress it (producing greater force underground) or give up in shame. The curriculum holds the struggle without condemning it.
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Formation Ground	Plato's account of the soul's struggle between appetite and reason in the Phaedrus — the charioteer trying to guide two horses of very different temperaments — is the foundational image. The Stoics developed a sophisticated set of practices for engaging desire: negative visualization (imagining the loss of what one desires), voluntary discomfort (practicing doing without what one is attached to), and the 'view from above' (seeing one's desires in their cosmic insignificance). These are not repression — they are training.
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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain the concept of disciplined engagement with desire and identify one desire they are working to redirect.
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Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to engage their desires as formation material rather than as evidence of failure.
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Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from being ruled by desire toward deliberate, disciplined engagement with it.
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L03 Lesson 3: My Relationship With My Parents

What do I owe my parents — and what do they owe me?

Why This Topic	Filial responsibility engaged with developmental honesty. Students in early adolescence are differentiating from parents. The curriculum holds the legitimate developmental tension without suppressing either the differentiation or the genuine obligation.
Content	What parents give, what they require, what they get wrong, and what one owes them anyway. The concept of gratitude as the foundation of the parent-child moral relationship — not blind obedience but genuine recognition of irreplaceable gift.
Approach & Methods	Appreciation exercises, honest reflection on the relationship, philosophical framing of filial duty. Teacher shares their relationship with their own parents — including its complexity.
Teaching Principles	Hold both honestly. Students told only to obey resent it. Students told only that their critical feelings are valid are untethered. Both are real.
Formation Ground	The philosopher Confucius placed filial piety (xiào) at the foundation of all moral development — the recognition that one's existence and formation are gifts received from specific people who are owed recognition and care in return. Western philosophy has been less systematic on this point, but the phenomenologist Edmund Husserl and the philosopher of care Nel Noddings have both argued that the foundational moral relationship is the relationship of care and dependency — and parents are the first and most formative instance of this.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can name one genuine gift they have received from their parents and one genuine tension, and hold both without collapsing into either gratitude-only or grievance-only.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to hold genuine complexity in the most important relationship of their lives.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from either uncritical deference or reactive rejection toward mature, accountable relationship.

L04 Lesson 4: Popularity and Integrity

What would I give up to be liked?

Why This Topic	Social courage at the peak developmental moment of peer orientation. The specific cost of integrity in a world where peer approval is neurologically primary is engaged directly and without minimization.
Content	What belonging to a particular peer group currently requires. The things given up for that belonging. The long-term cost of yielding integrity repeatedly for approval. The concept that genuine dignity cannot be given or taken by peers — it must be found elsewhere.
Approach & Methods	Scenario-based role-plays with real social cost, anonymous writing on what they have compromised for approval. Teacher shares their own integrity cost.
Teaching Principles	Honor the cost. Belonging is a genuine human need. The curriculum must acknowledge the real cost before asking for the sacrifice. Pretending the cost is small is dishonest — and students know it.
Formation Ground	The Stoic concept of 'hegemonikon' — the ruling faculty that determines one's responses — is relevant here: the person who has located their sense of worth in the ruling faculty rather than in external approval cannot be coerced by peer pressure. They care about belonging, as every human being does, but their identity does not depend on it. This is not indifference — it is inner freedom.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can describe one situation where they yielded integrity for approval and one where they held it, and explain what made the difference.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to notice the moment of choice between integrity and approval.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from approval-dependent identity toward integrity grounded in something more stable than peer opinion.

L05 Lesson 5: What Does It Mean to Be Human?

Is there a richer account of human identity than consumer culture offers?

Why This Topic	The philosophical account of human identity — as a being with a specific nature, specific capacities, and specific obligations that arise from that nature — is introduced as a genuine alternative to the consumer culture's account of the human being as a bundle of preferences and purchasing power.
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Content	The philosophical tradition's account of the human being: as a social and political animal (Aristotle), as the being capable of reason and freedom (Kant), as the being uniquely capable of love and commitment (Marcel), as the being who can ask the question of meaning (Frankl). Comparison with the consumer culture's account.
Approach & Methods	Comparative analysis of different accounts of human identity. Teacher articulates their own sense of what it means to be human.
Teaching Principles	Offer an alternative, not a condemnation. The richer account is not a restriction on the self — it is a more expansive and more demanding account of what the self actually is.
Formation Ground	The philosopher Viktor Frankl, writing from Auschwitz, argued that the human being is not fundamentally a pleasure-seeking or pain-avoiding organism but a meaning-seeking one. The philosopher Aristotle: the human being is a 'rational social animal' — capable of logos (reason and language) and therefore capable of political life, justice, and genuine friendship. These accounts are more demanding than the consumer account — but they are also more dignified. The student who inhabits one of them has more to live up to — and more to live for.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain two philosophical accounts of what it means to be human and describe how each changes what is expected of the human being.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to feel the elevation — not restriction — of a philosophically rich account of human identity.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from identity shaped by consumer culture toward identity grounded in a more demanding and more dignified philosophical account.

L06 Lesson 6: When the Interior Is in Pain

What do the wisdom traditions say about depression, anxiety, and suffering of the soul?

Why This Topic	Psychological health addressed directly and compassionately. Many students in Grade 7 are experiencing anxiety, low mood, or the beginning of clinical depression. The curriculum meets this without pathologizing it or spiritualizing it away.
Content	Depression and anxiety as real experiences, not weaknesses or

	failures. The overlap between what philosophers and contemplatives have called 'spiritual dryness,' 'dark night,' and 'acedia' and what modern psychology calls depression and anxiety. What genuinely helps: connection, movement, beauty, honest relationship, professional support.
Approach & Methods	Personal reflection (anonymous option), honest class discussion, multiple vocabularies alongside each other. Teacher is transparent about the reality of psychological struggle.
Teaching Principles	Destigmatize before teaching. Students ashamed of their mental health struggles cannot engage with any resources. The curriculum creates safety first.
Formation Ground	The philosopher Aristotle identified 'acedia' — a kind of spiritual torpor or numbness — as a recognized condition requiring specific responses. The medieval philosopher Thomas Aquinas analyzed it as a form of sorrow directed at a spiritual good. The existentialist philosopher Søren Kierkegaard wrote extensively about despair as the condition of the self that has not yet found its ground. Modern psychology has developed empirical accounts of depression and anxiety that parallel these philosophical descriptions in striking ways. The convergence suggests both are describing the same reality from different angles.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can describe the difference between depression as a recognized experience and depression as a spiritual failure, and identify two things that genuinely help their interior life.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to acknowledge their psychological struggles without shame.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from shame-based concealment of mental health struggles toward honest acknowledgment and help-seeking.

L07 Lesson 7: The Problem of Evil — Deepened

How can a good ultimate reality allow genuine horror?

Why This Topic	Theodicy deepened into genuine philosophical engagement. By Grade 7, students have encountered real suffering — their own and others'. The easy answers are not sufficient and the curriculum does not offer them.
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Content	The three main philosophical responses: free will defense (genuine freedom requires the real possibility of evil), soul-making theodicy (suffering is the forge of character), and honest mystery (some suffering exceeds any possible justification and must be held rather than explained). Their genuine strengths and their genuine limits.
Approach & Methods	Case study discussions, honest engagement with students' personal experiences of loss. Teacher shares their own struggle with this question without resolving it prematurely.
Teaching Principles	Do not close the question. Students whose genuine anguish is dismissed with a formula lose trust in the curriculum and in philosophical inquiry itself. The experience of being genuinely held in the difficulty is more formative than any answer.
Formation Ground	The philosopher Marilyn McCord Adams argues that horrendous evils require a personal God who suffers alongside the victim. Simone Weil described affliction as the place where genuine love is most acutely tested.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can articulate each of the three main responses to the problem of evil and explain why none of them fully closes the question.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to hold the question of evil honestly rather than defending against it.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from naive answers or angry dismissal toward the kind of trust that holds through genuine philosophical difficulty.

L08 Lesson 8: Knowing the Proper Place of Things

What do I owe to everything I encounter?

Why This Topic	The concept of propriety — knowing the appropriate response to each person, each situation, each encounter — introduced as the educational concept that underlies all genuine culture. This is the deepest concept of 'manners' — not social nicety but accurate moral perception.
Content	The concept of the proper due of each thing: what is owed to a parent (gratitude and recognition), to a friend (honesty and loyalty), to a stranger (basic dignity), to the natural world (care and restraint), to a book (genuine attention), to a moment (full presence). The concept

	that moving through the world well means perceiving accurately what each encounter requires.
Approach & Methods	Discussion of appropriate responses in different contexts, case study analysis, personal propriety audit. Teacher shares their own ongoing formation in this area.
Teaching Principles	This is not politeness. Social courtesy is one expression of this capacity. But the deeper concept is accurate moral perception: seeing what each encounter actually requires and responding accordingly. This cannot be reduced to rules because it requires the perception that rules cannot substitute for.
Formation Ground	The philosopher Syed Muhammad Naquib al-Attas coined the concept of 'ta'dib' — the recognition and acknowledgment of one's proper place in the order of things — as the foundational educational concept of Islamic civilization. But the concept has clear parallels in other traditions: Confucian ritual propriety (li), Aristotelian propriety (to prepon), the Stoic concept of 'appropriate actions' (kathêkon). All point at the same insight: genuine culture is the capacity to know what each encounter requires and to give it.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain propriety as more than politeness and apply it to give one example of the proper due of five different things in their daily life.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to move through the world with a sensitivity to what each encounter actually requires.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from socially conventional behavior toward genuine, perceptually grounded responsiveness.

L09 Lesson 9: Who Should I Walk With?

Who is my social environment forming me into?

Why This Topic	The formative power of companionship taken seriously — not as social advice but as a description of how character formation actually works. Who one walks with is one of the most consequential formation choices available.
Content	The philosophical insight: we become who we habitually associate with — not through conscious imitation alone but through the automatic absorption of dispositions, expectations, and patterns of attention that sustained proximity produces. The friend who improves

	vs. the friend who diminishes.
Approach & Methods	Companionship analysis (who am I becoming with each of my companions?), philosophical framework, class sharing. Teacher shares their most formative friendship.
Teaching Principles	Honest without condemning. The analysis is offered as self-knowledge, not as a judgment of others.
Formation Ground	Aristotle's three types of friendship — based on pleasure, utility, and genuine care for the other's character — place companionship at the center of moral formation. The philosopher Pierre Bourdieu's concept of habitus demonstrates the mechanism: social fields automatically generate dispositions in those who inhabit them. The practical implication is exactly what Aristotle's moral psychology predicted: who you walk with is one of the most powerful formation forces available.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can analyze two of their friendships by asking: who am I becoming with this person?
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to see their friendships as formation environments, not merely sources of enjoyment.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from friendship-by-proximity toward deliberate selection of companions who raise one's formation.

L10 Lesson 10: The Gap Between Who I Say I Am and Who I Am

Is there a gap between my stated identity and my lived one?

Why This Topic	The gap between professed values and lived reality — addressed honestly, not as condemnation but as a diagnostic that, once named, can be engaged. The student who can name this gap in themselves is already at a more advanced stage of self-knowledge than the one who defends against its recognition.
Content	The three dimensions of the gap: stated beliefs vs. actual functioning beliefs, public self vs. private self, stated values vs. actual priorities as revealed by behavior. The concept of the unexamined drift — not conscious hypocrisy but the gradual drift of the unexamined life.
Approach & Methods	Anonymous self-assessment, class discussion. Teacher shares their own experience of this gap with genuine honesty.

Teaching Principles	Self-diagnosis as liberation. The student who can honestly name the gap is already in the reflective stage of selfhood. The one who defends against it remains in the reactive stage.
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Formation Ground	The philosopher Harry Frankfurt's concept of 'wholehearted' vs. 'ambivalent' willing captures the phenomenon: the ambivalent person has desires that pull against each other, and their choices do not fully express any of them. This produces the gap between stated and lived values that the curriculum is addressing. The path forward is not willpower but integration — aligning desire with value through sustained formation.
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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can identify one area of genuine gap in their own life and describe one step toward closing it.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to see their own gap without shame — as the starting point of formation rather than evidence of failure.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from unreflective gap toward genuine integration of stated and lived values.

GRADE 8 — Age 13–14

Self-Knowledge, the Examined Life, and What We Are Actually Organized Around

Grade 8 is the deepest self-examination year in the middle school arc. The curriculum introduces the examined life as a formal practice. The concept of self-verification — finding truth by oneself and in oneself, rather than merely inheriting it — is introduced as a formal epistemological and formation concept. The concept of functional devotion receives its most systematic treatment. The conscience/inner critic distinction is one of the most practically important lessons in the curriculum.

L01 Lesson 1: Conscience or Inner Critic?

Is the voice that judges me actually my conscience?

Why This Topic

One of the most practically important distinctions in the entire curriculum. Students who mistake the inner critic for the conscience cannot access genuine moral guidance — they are governed by a punishing psychological system while their actual moral perception lies dormant.

Content

The difference between conscience (oriented toward truth and repair — it names what was wrong and points toward what would make it right) and the inner critic (oriented toward control and shame — it punishes without pointing toward repair). The diagnostic: does this voice help me grow or keep me stuck?

Approach & Methods

Journaling on the inner voice, class discussion, philosophical map of the distinction. Teacher shares their own journey of distinguishing these voices.

Teaching Principles

The diagnostic matters enormously. Students who suppress genuine moral perception because it feels like more self-criticism are losing their moral compass. Students who obey the inner critic because it feels moral are imprisoned by a psychological system that has nothing to do with genuine ethics.

Formation Ground

The psychologist June Price Tangney's research distinguishes shame (the feeling that 'I am bad') from guilt (the feeling that 'I did something bad'): shame produces hiding, aggression, and paralysis; guilt produces repair, apology, and behavior change. The philosopher Immanuel Kant's 'practical reason' — the faculty of genuine moral judgment — points always toward what one ought to do, never merely toward self-punishment. These distinctions map onto the conscience/inner critic distinction the curriculum is drawing.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual

Students can distinguish between the conscience and the inner critic using specific criteria and apply the distinction to a recent experience.

Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to identify which inner voice is guiding them at any given moment.
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Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from undifferentiated inner noise toward the capacity to hear genuine moral perception clearly.
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L02 Lesson 2: Shame vs. Guilt

Is what I'm feeling helping me grow or keeping me stuck?

Why This Topic	The single most practically important emotional distinction for moral formation. Shame and guilt are structurally different and produce completely different outcomes — one enables repair and growth, the other produces hiding and stagnation.
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Content	Guilt: I did something wrong — reparable, relational, oriented toward repair and change. Shame: I am something wrong — identity-level, non-reparable by action, producing hiding or aggression. The path from shame to guilt to genuine repair.
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Approach & Methods	Personal experience mapping (which feeling is more common?), case study analysis. Teacher shares their own shame-to-guilt-to-repair journey genuinely.
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Teaching Principles	This lesson can be genuinely transformative. Students who have been living in shame and encounter this distinction for the first time often experience immediate relief — the sense that the state they have been in has a name and a path forward.
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Formation Ground	The psychologist June Price Tangney's research is definitive: people prone to shame (as opposed to guilt) are more likely to engage in destructive behaviors, less likely to make amends, and more likely to become angry or defensive. People prone to guilt show greater empathy, are more motivated to repair harm, and show better overall adjustment. This is not a small distinction — it is one of the strongest predictors of moral functioning available.
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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can define shame and guilt as structurally different and describe one experience where they felt shame and how it affected them.
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Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to distinguish shame from guilt in their own interior experience.
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Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from shame-based moral paralysis toward guilt-based accountability and genuine repair.
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L03 Lesson 3: Identity, Nature, and the Modern Confusion

Where does a coherent account of human identity come from?

Why This Topic	Human identity — particularly in dimensions the contemporary world treats as politically contested — approached philosophically: what does the natural order of things disclose about who we are, and how should that disclosure be received?
Content	What the philosophical traditions of both East and West have said about human nature and its differentiated expressions. The concept of complementarity — that genuine differences can be sources of completion rather than competition. The critique of both domination models and dissolution models of human difference.
Approach & Methods	Honest discussion of what students have absorbed from culture about identity, comparison with what the philosophical tradition offers. Teacher engages with genuine intellectual courage.
Teaching Principles	Start with what they have absorbed. Students are already formed by cultural identity norms. Engaging that prior formation before offering a philosophical alternative is the only approach that reaches the actual question.
Formation Ground	The philosopher Charles Taylor's account of 'authenticity' — that genuine selfhood requires discovering and articulating what is distinctively one's own — applies here. The philosopher Alasdair MacIntyre's account of 'practices' — forms of human activity with internal goods and standards of excellence — provides a framework for understanding how different human capacities can be organized toward genuine flourishing. Both accounts support a view of human difference as genuine and formative rather than arbitrary.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can articulate the philosophical account of human nature as complementary and explain how it differs from both domination and dissolution models.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to examine where their sense of identity comes from and whether it serves their genuine flourishing.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from culturally absorbed

	identity formation toward a philosophically grounded sense of who one is.
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L04 Lesson 4: The Examined Life

What would I find if I looked at my life honestly?

Why This Topic	Honest self-examination as a formal practice. The claim — made by Socrates and confirmed by every tradition that has thought seriously about character — that the unexamined life is less than fully human.
Content	Socrates' claim that 'the unexamined life is not worth living' — its origins, meaning, and the practice it calls for. The methodology of honest self-examination: what questions to ask, how to ask them without self-condemnation, what to do with what one finds.
Approach & Methods	Extended reflection exercise, Socratic dialogue around 'what do I actually believe about myself and the world?', structured self-interview. Teacher shares their own examination practice.
Teaching Principles	Create the conditions rather than demand the examination. The curriculum cannot force genuine self-examination — it can only make it safe, structured, and modeled. The teacher's own practice of self-examination is the most powerful element of this lesson.
Formation Ground	Socrates' claim — 'the unexamined life is not worth living' — from his Apology (written by Plato) is one of the most consequential statements in the history of philosophy. It places self-knowledge not as a luxury but as a requirement of genuine humanity. The philosopher Marcus Aurelius practiced this nightly in his Meditations. The philosopher Montaigne made it the organizing principle of the essay form. The psychologist Carl Rogers built his entire therapeutic approach on the conviction that genuine self-examination is the condition of genuine development.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can describe what genuine self-examination requires and identify one thing they discovered about themselves through honest reflection.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to experience genuine self-examination rather than performance of it.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from the unexamined life toward a sustained practice of honest self-knowledge.

L05 Lesson 5: What We Consume Consumes Us

Am I choosing what enters my mind — or is it choosing me?

Why This Topic	Entertainment, media, and digital content as formation forces: the moral quality of what one habitually attends to shapes one's desires, perceptions, and moral imagination — for better or worse.
Content	How media shapes moral imagination: what one watches and listens to habitually shapes what one finds attractive, what one finds funny, what one finds normal. The concept of actively curating what one allows to enter the interior — not as restriction but as formation practice.
Approach & Methods	Media audit ('what do I consume? what does it do to my interior?'), discussion of deliberate curation as a positive practice. Teacher shares their own media formation.
Teaching Principles	Analytical, not preachy. Students given tools to analyze their own consumption engage deeply. Students lectured about media disengage immediately.
Formation Ground	The philosopher Iris Murdoch: 'I can only choose within the world I can see.' What one habitually attends to shapes what one can see. The philosopher Albert Borgmann's 'device paradigm': devices that conceal their mechanism while delivering commodified goods replace genuine engagement with mediated consumption. Both arguments converge: the quality of what one habitually consumes shapes the quality of what one can perceive and therefore the quality of what one can choose.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can conduct a media audit and describe two specific effects that their media consumption has had on their desires or mood.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to see media consumption as a formation activity with real consequences.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from passive media consumption toward deliberate curation of what is allowed to enter the interior.

L06 Lesson 6: The Fragmented Self

Why do I feel like I am many different people?

Why This Topic	Identity fragmentation — the experience of being contextually variable rather than internally consistent — named as a structural feature of contemporary life rather than a personal failure.
Content	The modern self as decentered, multiple, and contextually variable. Sources of fragmentation: digital identity multiplicity, consumer culture's invitation to constantly reinvent oneself, the loss of a single formative tradition. Integration — the alternative — as the curriculum's formation goal.
Approach & Methods	Personal fragmentation mapping, philosophical readings on the unified self. Teacher discusses their own integration work.
Teaching Principles	Name the structural cause. Students who feel fragmented often blame themselves. Understanding fragmentation as an engineered feature of modern life — rather than a personal deficiency — is the beginning of genuine response to it.
Formation Ground	The philosopher Charles Taylor traces the fragmentation of modern identity through the 'Sources of the Self' — the dissolution of the single authoritative framework (religion, tradition, community) that once provided the organizing center. The sociologist Anthony Giddens describes the contemporary self as a 'reflexive project' — constantly under construction, without a stable foundation. Integration — finding a genuine center — is what the curriculum's formation arc is working toward.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain why modern life produces fragmented selves and describe what an integrated self would feel like.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to see their fragmentation as structural rather than personal, and to desire integration.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from fragmented, contextually variable selfhood toward unified, integrated identity.

L07 Lesson 7: Freedom and Responsibility

Am I responsible for who I have become?

Why This Topic	The question of moral responsibility applied to character formation: to what extent am I responsible for who I am — given the forces that shaped me without my choosing?
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Content	The philosophical position: genuine human freedom is real — even given the forces of heredity, environment, and circumstance. The person shaped by difficult circumstances is not fully determined by them. Responsibility is real, though it is calibrated to the degree of genuine freedom available.
Approach & Methods	Philosophical thought experiments, case study of severely constrained circumstances. Teacher engages with genuine philosophical interest.
Teaching Principles	Hold the tension. The curriculum does not resolve the free will question quickly — it holds the philosophical difficulty while maintaining that genuine responsibility is real. Both the denial of responsibility and the crushing over-attribution of responsibility are formation failures.
Formation Ground	The philosopher Jean-Paul Sartre's radical claim that humans are 'condemned to be free' — that even the refusal to choose is a choice — goes too far. The philosopher Harry Frankfurt's 'hierarchical' account of freedom — that genuine freedom is the alignment of one's first-order desires (what one wants) with one's second-order desires (what one wants to want) — provides a more nuanced account. The Stoic position: what is within one's control (one's responses) is genuinely within one's control; what is not (external circumstances) is genuinely not.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can articulate a nuanced account of moral responsibility that acknowledges both constraining circumstances and genuine agency.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to accept genuine responsibility for their formation without being crushed by it.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from either fatalistic denial of responsibility or crushing over-responsibility toward a balanced account.

L08 Lesson 8: What We Are Actually Organized Around

Are we devoted to what we say we are devoted to?

Why This Topic	Functional devotion — what one is actually organized around — examined systematically: what one organizes one's time around, what one fears losing most, what one will compromise anything for. Making the gap between stated and actual devotion visible.
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Content	The four forms of misdirected devotion examined at depth: performing for others' approval (needing others' approval to feel worth), self-aggrandizement (placing oneself at the center of one's concerns), love of praise and recognition (being organized around how one is perceived), and following immediate desire (being organized around whatever the reactive self wants). Each examined for its symptoms, mechanism, and cost.
Approach & Methods	Extended honest self-reflection, case study analysis, philosophical framework. Teacher models honest self-disclosure.
Teaching Principles	Safety before depth. This is a demanding lesson. It must be delivered in a context of genuine acceptance — the goal is liberation from the tyranny of misdirected devotion, not humiliation.
Formation Ground	The philosopher Paul Tillich's concept of 'ultimate concern' — what one is ultimately devoted to — provides the framework. David Foster Wallace's 2005 Kenyon College commencement address: 'In the day-to-day trenches of adult life, there is actually no such thing as atheism... Everybody worships. The only choice we get is what to worship.' The philosopher Harry Frankfurt's account of love as what one's will is organized around: what one loves is what one's practical identity is constituted by.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can define all four forms of misdirected devotion and identify the one most operative in their own life.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to examine their motivations for moral and social action with genuine honesty.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from approval-seeking or self-centered motivation toward genuinely other-directed and integrated motivation.

L09 Lesson 9: Doubt Without Resources

What do I do when I'm not sure what I believe?

Why This Topic	Doubt as a developmental reality and a formation resource. The student who has never been allowed to genuinely doubt — or who has never been given the tools to engage doubt productively — is genuinely vulnerable when certainty wavers.
Content	The normalcy of doubt in the lives of the most intellectually serious people. The distinction between productive doubt (which drives

	inquiry toward genuine knowledge) and destructive doubt (which drives withdrawal from inquiry). What to do when certainty retreats: stay in the question, seek better knowledge, maintain one's practices.
Approach & Methods	Honest class discussion (anonymous option) on genuine doubts they carry. Teacher shares their own intellectual questions without resolving them prematurely.
Teaching Principles	Normalize before stabilizing. The curriculum that has never acknowledged doubt has no authority when doubt arrives. The student who has been told that genuine inquiry is dangerous will have no resources when genuine questions arise.
Formation Ground	The philosopher William James distinguished between 'live' and 'dead' hypotheses and between 'forced' and 'not forced' options: we must decide some questions under conditions of genuine uncertainty because failing to decide is itself a decision with consequences. The philosopher Alvin Plantinga: faith is not the absence of doubt but its persistence alongside genuine uncertainty. The philosopher John Henry Newman: 'Ten thousand difficulties do not make one doubt.' The curriculum's approach to doubt is exactly Newman's: difficulties are held and engaged, not suppressed or surrendered to.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can distinguish productive from destructive doubt and describe one genuine intellectual uncertainty they are holding and one resource for engaging it.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to hold doubt as a legitimate formation experience rather than a spiritual or intellectual emergency.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from denial of doubt or collapse under it toward confident, curious engagement with genuine questions.

L10 Lesson 10: The Middle School Arc: A Reckoning

Who have I become across these three years of formation?

Why This Topic	The closing lesson of the middle school arc. Before students enter the high school years and their more philosophical depth, they pause and take honest stock of where the formation has brought them. This is the earliest full muhasaba of the curriculum.
Content	A comprehensive honest self-assessment using all the formation

	vocabulary developed across Grades 6, 7, and 8: which stage of the self am I primarily in? What patterns of misdirected devotion are most active in me? Where is the gap between my stated values and how I live? What has genuinely shifted since Grade 6?
Approach & Methods	Extended reflective writing, small group sharing (with private option), personal letter to the Grade 6 self. Teacher shares their own honest self-assessment from a comparable period of their life.
Teaching Principles	Honest before celebratory. The formation audit that is only positive is not honest. This lesson has earned the right to ask for genuine honesty by three years of building safety. And genuine honesty here is the best possible preparation for the high school years.
Formation Ground	The philosopher Marcus Aurelius practiced a nightly self-examination across decades. The Islamic muhasaba tradition, the Stoic evening review, and the Jesuit examen all converge on the same practice: periodic honest accounting of where one stands relative to where one wants to be. This lesson is the first comprehensive version of that practice in the curriculum.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can write an honest self-accounting that identifies two areas of genuine growth, two ongoing struggles, and one formation intention for Grade 9.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to see themselves clearly across time, not just in the present moment, and to feel both accountability and genuine possibility.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from unconscious drift through middle school toward self-authoring entry into the high school formation arc.

GRADE 9 — Age 14-15

Consciousness, the Cosmos, and the Architecture of Desire

Grade 9 opens the high school arc with genuine philosophical depth. Avicennas Floating Man opens the year with the most direct question possible: what is the self? The concept of original nature is developed philosophically. The hidden treasure hadith provides the cosmological horizon. The architecture of desire gives students a precise map of how desire is generated.

L01 Lesson 1: The Floating Man

Who am I without my body, senses, or memories?

Why This Topic	Avicennas thought experiment opens the high school formation arc with the most direct question possible: what is the self?
Content	Avicennas argument: a person suspended in air, without any sensory contact with the world, would still be aware of their own existence. Consciousness itself is the irreducible residue. What does this tell us about the nature of the self and its relationship to the body?
Approach & Methods	Extended Socratic seminar built around the thought experiment, personal consciousness exploration. Teacher models genuine philosophical engagement.
Teaching Principles	Open with the question, not the answer. The greatest gift of this lesson is the experience of genuine philosophical wonder about ones own existence.
Formation Ground	Avicenna (Ibn Sina, 980-1037) developed the Floating Man argument in his Book of Salvation. It anticipates Descartes cogito by six centuries. The philosopher David Chalmers has reformulated this as the hard problem of consciousness: why there is something it is like to be conscious rather than merely information processing.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can reconstruct Avicennas Floating Man argument and explain what it discloses about the relationship between consciousness and body.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to experience genuine wonder at the mystery of their own consciousness.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from an unconscious materialist account of the self toward genuine openness to the irreducibly first-person character of consciousness.

L02 Lesson 2: Original Nature and Its Recovery

What was I before I became who I am?

Why This Topic	The concept of an original nature that precedes social conditioning, developed philosophically as the foundation of the formation arc.
Content	The philosophical concept of original nature: the God-given or naturally given orientation of the person toward truth, beauty, and goodness. How this original nature is distorted by cultural overlay, fear, distraction, and habit. Formation as the recovery and actualization of what was always already present.
Approach & Methods	Personal original nature archaeology, class discussion on universal moral intuitions. Teacher shares their own experience of recovering original nature.
Teaching Principles	Frame formation as recovery, not construction. Students who feel that character education is asking them to become someone foreign to themselves disengage. Students who understand it as becoming who they genuinely are engage deeply.
Formation Ground	The philosopher Rousseau argued that human beings are naturally good and corrupted by society. The Confucian philosopher Mencius argued that all human beings have the four beginnings as seeds of virtue. The Stoics argued that every human being is born with a natural orientation toward virtue. The Islamic concept of fitra captures all three: an original God-given nature oriented toward truth, distorted by accumulation, and recoverable through deliberate formation.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain the concept of original nature and identify two things they know to be true that they did not learn from any external source.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to experience their formation work as recovery rather than construction.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from identity constructed entirely from external sources toward the recovery of the authentic original self.

L03 Lesson 3: What Is a Human Being For?

Do I have a purpose built into who I am or do I invent one?

Why This Topic	The telos question in its most explicit philosophical form: against existentialisms claim that existence precedes essence, the position that the human being has a built-in purpose discovered rather than invented.
Content	The sacred hadith of the Hidden Treasure: I was a hidden treasure and I loved to be known, so I created creation. Cited alongside Leibniz's account of why there is something rather than nothing, and the philosophers concept of the cosmos as oriented toward self-knowledge.
Approach & Methods	Philosophical debate between existentialist and essentialist positions on human purpose. Teacher articulates their own sense of purpose.
Teaching Principles	Make the stakes clear. Whether purpose is discovered or invented determines how a person relates to suffering, failure, and the demands of moral life.
Formation Ground	Sartre's existentialist claim that existence precedes essence and man is condemned to be free is the dominant modern position. Against it, Aristotle's teleological account: every being has a function appropriate to its nature, and eudaimonia is the actualization of that function. The hidden treasure hadith positions the human being as the creature through whom the cosmos comes to know itself consciously.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can articulate the existentialist and essentialist accounts of human purpose and explain which they find more compelling and why.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to feel that their existence is cosmologically significant rather than arbitrary.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from purpose-as-self-invention toward purpose-as-discovery and participation.

L04 Lesson 4: The Ethics of Attention

What does it mean to spend my attention well?

Why This Topic	Attention as a moral category. In an economy that monetizes it, the capacity to direct one's own attention is one of the most critical moral capacities available.
Content	The attention economy and its design goals. The concept of

	heedlessness as the spiritual disease that distraction produces and genuine presence as its counter-practice and what it makes possible.
Approach & Methods	Attention audit, contemplative practice session. Teacher models deliberate attention visibly.
Teaching Principles	Attention as moral choice. The allocation of attention is the allocation of ones most fundamental resource and the precondition for every form of genuine knowledge and genuine relationship.
Formation Ground	The philosopher Simone Weil: Attention is the rarest and purest form of generosity. The philosopher William James: The faculty of voluntarily bringing back a wandering attention, over and over again, is the very root of judgment, character, and will. The Stoic practice of prosoche, sustained attention to oneself, is the foundation of all Stoic ethical practice.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can describe the philosophical concept of heedlessness and identify two specific practices that cultivate presence over distraction.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to experience the quality difference between scattered and gathered attention.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from chronic distraction toward the capacity for sustained, deliberate, formative attention.

L05 Lesson 5: Virtue Ethics vs. Rule Ethics

Is there a difference between following rules and being a good person?

Why This Topic	The first systematic comparative ethics lesson. Virtue ethics, deontological ethics, and consequentialism compared as lived frameworks with real differences.
Content	How each framework handles a real moral dilemma. Their genuine strengths and limits. The synthesis: genuine character operating within genuine obligations oriented toward genuine goods.
Approach & Methods	Case study analysis through three ethical lenses, class debate. Teacher engages with genuine philosophical openness.
Teaching Principles	The comparison is the lesson. Students who evaluate multiple frameworks develop stronger moral reasoning than students given

	one framework and told it is correct.
Formation Ground	Aristotles virtue ethics: the morally excellent person is not the rule-follower but the person of practical wisdom who perceives what each situation requires. Kants deontological ethics: persons must always be treated as ends, never merely as means. Mills consequentialism: the right action produces the greatest good for the greatest number. The natural law tradition and the Islamic tradition both approximate a synthesis that holds all three in a structured relationship.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can apply all three ethical frameworks to a single case and explain which aspects of each they find most and least adequate.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to develop genuine moral reasoning rather than mere rule application.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from rule-following as the primary mode of moral life toward virtue and practical wisdom as the center.

L06 Lesson 6: The Social Field as Formation

Who is my environment producing in me without my permission?

Why This Topic	The sociological account of automatic formation: social environments generate dispositions without anyone deciding it. The most important formation force in adolescence is the social field.
Content	Pierre Bourdieus concept of habitus: the social field generates automatic dispositions through sustained immersion. These dispositions are not consciously chosen but absorbed. The formation question: what is my habitus, and is it what I would choose?
Approach & Methods	Social environment audit, comparison with the philosophical account of companionship as formation. Teacher maps their own habitus.
Teaching Principles	Structural awareness before individual agency. Students who believe character is entirely individual are blind to the most powerful formation forces operating on them.
Formation Ground	Bourdieu's concept of habitus in Outline of a Theory of Practice (1977) is the most rigorous sociological account of automatic formation available. Aristotle anticipated it: We are what we repeatedly do. The practical implication: choosing ones companions and institutions are

	formation choices of the highest order.
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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can define habitus and identify three dispositions their social environment has given them that they did not consciously choose.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to see their social environment as a formation agent and to choose more deliberately.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from unconscious formation by social environment toward deliberate construction of a formation-positive environment.

L07 Lesson 7: The Architecture of Desire

Why do I want what I want and can that change?

Why This Topic	Avicennas five internal senses as a systematic map of how desire is generated before the will has a chance to act. Understanding this map is the precondition for genuine formation.
Content	The five internal senses: common sense, retention, imagination, estimation (wahm, attributing value), and memory. The central role of the estimative faculty in generating desire by attributing value before the rational faculty can evaluate. Formation as reshaping what the estimative faculty assigns value to.
Approach & Methods	Desire archaeology (where does this desire come from?), exploration of the estimative and rational distinction through personal examples. Teacher shares their own desire architecture.
Teaching Principles	Map before moralizing. Students who understand the mechanism of desire are far better equipped to engage it than students who are simply told to resist it.
Formation Ground	Avicennas five internal senses represent the most sophisticated pre-modern account of the cognitive architecture of desire. The estimative faculty corresponds to what modern cognitive science calls the affective appraisal system: the automatic emotional evaluation that occurs before conscious reflection. Daniel Kahnemans System 1 is the contemporary equivalent. Genuine formation works at this level.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can name the five internal senses and explain how the estimative faculty generates desire before the rational faculty can
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	evaluate.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to observe their desire-formation process rather than simply experiencing its outputs.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from being governed by unreflective desire toward the capacity to engage desire at the level of its formation.

L08 Lesson 8: Levels of Knowing

Is certainty possible and what level of certainty about ultimate reality is available?

Why This Topic	Advanced epistemology: the spectrum from opinion to certainty, and what level of certainty about the deepest questions is available and through which mode of knowing.
Content	Three levels of knowing about any significant reality: knowing by description, knowing by sight or direct perception, and knowing by being or full experiential participation. The question: which level about ultimate reality is possible, and through which of the three modes of knowing?
Approach & Methods	Epistemology case studies, class debate on whether certainty is possible. Teacher engages with genuine intellectual humility.
Teaching Principles	Confidence through precision. Students with a precise epistemological map are genuinely equipped for intellectual challenge.
Formation Ground	Bertrand Russell distinguished knowledge by acquaintance from knowledge by description. The Islamic tradition developed this into three levels: ilm al-yaqin (knowing by reliable report), ayn al-yaqin (knowing by direct perception), and haqq al-yaqin (knowing by full experiential identification). The mystical traditions across cultures consistently claim the third level as the highest and most direct.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain the three levels of knowing and describe which level they currently have about their core beliefs and why.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to become precise about the quality of their own knowing.

Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from vague conviction or vague doubt toward increasingly precise, examined, and embodied knowing.
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L09 Lesson 9: The Cosmos as Ongoing Act

Is the universe an object or an ongoing act?

Why This Topic	The difference between seeing the cosmos as a finished machine and seeing it as an ongoing, actively sustained, meaningful reality changes how every question about nature, science, and meaning is approached.
Content	The philosophical position: the cosmos is not merely a collection of mechanisms but an ongoing, actively sustained reality that points beyond itself. Continuous creation versus the deist clockmaker. The implications of a cosmos that is continuously maintained rather than merely set in motion.
Approach & Methods	Philosophical discussion of the two cosmologies, readings from natural philosophy. Teacher models the shift in perception.
Teaching Principles	This lesson is about perception, not information. The goal is that students begin to see the world as potentially alive with significance rather than merely mechanical.
Formation Ground	Alfred North Whiteheads process philosophy holds that reality is fundamentally processual: events rather than things, acts rather than objects. Leibniz's account of continuous creation: God preserves things by a continual production of them, which is similar to a creation. The Islamic concept of tajalli (divine self-disclosure) describes the cosmos as the ongoing self-expression of its source. The convergence of multiple traditions on this insight is philosophically significant.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain the difference between the clockmaker cosmos and the ongoing-act cosmos and describe how this changes how they look at the natural world.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to begin seeing the world as potentially disclosive rather than merely mechanical.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from a mechanistic cosmology toward an open, wondering engagement with what the cosmos existence and character might disclose.

L10 Lesson 10: Why Be Good When No One Is Watching?

What is the difference between integrity and performance?

Why This Topic	The central question of the formation arc. What makes moral behavior consistent across observed and unobserved contexts? What is the interior condition that makes this consistency possible?
Content	Genuine integrity: the alignment of interior and exterior such that one behaves the same way regardless of who is watching because the behavior flows from a genuine interior orientation rather than external compliance. Moral consistency as the test of character.
Approach & Methods	Extended reflection on private versus public moral self, Socratic discussion on what motivates when no one is watching. Teacher shares their own development of interior integrity.
Teaching Principles	Make the question personal. This is the central question of the formation arc. Everything else in the curriculum has been building to it.
Formation Ground	The concept of ihsan, excellence in the awareness of being seen even when no human eye is watching, is cited alongside the Stoic concept of prosoche, the Kantian concept of acting from duty rather than consequences, and the virtue ethics concept of the person of genuine character who acts rightly as an expression of who they are. All point at the same interior condition.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can articulate what makes moral consistency across contexts possible and explain the difference between performing virtue and genuinely inhabiting it.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to feel the difference between performing morality and living from a genuine interior orientation.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from compliance-based morality toward the excellence of one who acts rightly because it expresses who they genuinely are.

GRADE 10 — Age 15-16

Narrative Identity, Exemplary Character, and the Epistemological Crisis of Modernity

Grade 10 integrates the formation work of previous years while deepening the critique of modernity to its epistemological roots. The Baconian declaration that knowledge is power and its catastrophic consequences is examined alongside the perennial account of knowledge as a trust enabling fuller humanity. Exemplary character is studied as the actualization of the fully realized human being. Hidden devotion receives its most comprehensive treatment.

L01 Lesson 1: The Examined Life: Who Have I Been?

If I looked at my life as a story what story would I see?

Why This Topic	Narrative identity at depth: the self as a temporal unity with themes, patterns, and recurring choices. Making that story visible creates both honest accountability and genuine possibility.
Content	Life as a narrative with structure, themes, patterns, and a narrator. Identifying the story one has been living. Noticing patterns of choice, failure, and growth. The possibility of reauthoring because the story is not over.
Approach & Methods	Extended life narrative writing, pattern identification, small group sharing. Teacher shares their own life narrative and its patterns.
Teaching Principles	The narrative frame holds both continuity and possibility enabling honest assessment without identity collapse.
Formation Ground	Paul Ricoeurs narrative identity theory: personal identity is constituted by the story one tells about oneself, located within larger stories of community and history. Dan McAdamss life story model: people construct identity by internalizing experience into a personal myth that gives life unity and meaning.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can identify three recurring patterns in their life narrative and explain what they reveal about their character.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to see their life as a story with agency, something they are writing not merely living.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from passive story-inhabiting toward active narrative self-authorship.

L02 Lesson 2: Knowledge as Gift vs. Knowledge as Power

Is knowledge a tool for domination or a trust enabling fuller humanity?

Why This Topic	The most consequential epistemological distinction in the curriculum. Francis Bacons declaration that knowledge is power and its consequences contrasted with the perennial account of knowledge as enabling fuller humanity.
Content	Bacons declaration and its consequences traced: the Scientific Revolution orienting inquiry toward utility, the Industrial Revolution converting nature into resource, the digital revolution converting attention into commodity. The alternative: knowledge as participation in the intelligibility of the cosmos, valuable because it enables one to be more fully human.
Approach & Methods	Intellectual history discussion, case studies of knowledge used for domination versus knowledge used in service. Teacher articulates their own relationship to the knowledge they hold.
Teaching Principles	Make the epistemological assumption visible. Students absorb the Baconian assumption without knowing they have done so. Naming the assumption is the first step toward examining it.
Formation Ground	Francis Bacon (1620): Knowledge is power, the foundational principle of modernity. Al-Ghazali, Seyyed Hossein Nasr, and Michael Polanyi all argue in different ways that knowledge is not neutral power but participatory engagement with reality that transforms the knower. The measure of knowledge is not what it enables one to do but what it enables one to be.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can articulate the Baconian versus the perennial accounts of knowledge and explain the real-world consequences of each.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to examine their own unconscious assumptions about what knowledge is for.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from a Baconian orientation toward the perennial orientation of knowledge as transformative participation in reality.

L03 Lesson 3: The Interior Life as a Science

Is there a rigorous account of how the soul develops?

Why This Topic	The great traditions of interior formation presented as a systematic
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	account of how the interior life develops, with stages, practices, and observable progress.
Content	The stations of the interior journey from multiple traditions: the Stoic progression from discipline through justice to wisdom, the Sufi maqamat from tawba through sabr to mahabbah, the Christian contemplative stages of purgation, illumination, and union, and the Buddhist path. The concept of traveling a path with structure and guidance.
Approach & Methods	Reading of selected passages from multiple wisdom traditions, personal mapping of where they are on the path. Teacher shares their own engagement with interior formation.
Teaching Principles	Present as a science, not a spiritual achievement. The stations are a descriptive map, not a checklist of accomplishments.
Formation Ground	William James documented the range of interior contemplative experiences across traditions in <i>The Varieties of Religious Experience</i> (1902), finding striking convergences. Al-Qushayris <i>Risala</i> (1045) systematized the Sufi account. John of the Cross described the contemplative path in the Christian tradition. The convergences suggest all three are describing the same reality from different angles.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can name five stages of interior development from two different traditions and explain the difference between a station and a state.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to locate themselves within a structured developmental map of interior formation.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from ad hoc interior effort toward structured purposeful formation practice.

L04 Lesson 4: What Has Modernity Done to Us?

Are we living in a crisis we did not choose?

Why This Topic	The critique of modernity at philosophical depth: the Cartesian rupture, the Baconian conversion of knowledge into power, Webers disenchantment, and their consequences for the human being.
Content	The sequence: Descartes separates the thinking subject from the

	natural world. Bacon converts the knowing subject into a dominating subject. Weber names the consequence: the disenchantment of the world, a cosmos stripped of inherent meaning available only for use. Taylor names the further consequence: the loss of the sources of the self that gave moral life its depth.
Approach & Methods	Readings from Charles Taylors A Secular Age and Seyyed Hossein Nasrs Islam and the Plight of Modern Man. Teacher shares their own encounter with modernitys formation pressures.
Teaching Principles	Name the prison before proposing the escape. Students who understand the structural features of modern life that work against formation are better equipped to resist them deliberately.
Formation Ground	Charles Taylors A Secular Age (2007) traces how the immanent frame came to seem like the natural default rather than a specific philosophical construction. Seyyed Hossein Nasrs Knowledge and the Sacred (1981) traces the desacralization of knowledge. All converge on the same insight: modernity is not neutral and has a specific formation effect.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can trace the intellectual sequence from Descartes through Bacon through Weber and explain how it produced the formation crisis.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to see modernitys pathologies as consequences of specific philosophical choices rather than inevitable features of progress.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from unconscious modern formation toward deliberate engagement with the resources that counter it.

L05 Lesson 5: Functional Devotion: The Full Diagnosis

What am I actually devoted to when I think I am devoted to the right things?

Why This Topic	The most comprehensive treatment of functional misdirection: how the devoted act can be redirected from genuine good toward oneself without the person noticing.
Content	The four forms of misdirected devotion: performing for approval (riya in Islamic tradition), self-admiration (ujb, narcissism), love of recognition (philodoxia in Greek tradition), and following immediate desire (akrasia). Each examined for its mechanism, symptoms, and

	the way it corrupts genuine devotion.
Approach & Methods	Extended honest reflection on each form, philosophical texts from multiple traditions. Teacher models genuine honest disclosure.
Teaching Principles	Deliver in a context of genuine acceptance. This lesson must be experienced as liberation rather than condemnation.
Formation Ground	Aristotle identified philodoxia, love of reputation, as a main distortion of the love of genuine honor. The Stoics identified seeking externals as confusing the genuinely good with what merely appears good. Augustine identified libido dominandi as the root of social evil. David Foster Wallace: everyone worships. The only choice we get is what to worship. All point at the same insight: the greatest obstacle to genuine devotion is usually the subtle redirection of devotion toward the self.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can define all four forms of misdirected devotion and identify the one most operative in their own life.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to examine their motivations for action with genuine honesty.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from approval-seeking or self-centered motivation toward genuinely integrated other-directed motivation.

L06 Lesson 6: The Exemplary Character

What would it mean to model one's character on the best example available?

Why This Topic	The exemplary character studied as a formation model. The Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him) presented alongside Socrates, Marcus Aurelius, and other exemplars of philosophical and moral excellence.
Content	The four qualities of exemplary character: truthfulness (sidq, Socratic speaking what one truly believes), trustworthiness (amana, being reliable in one's commitments), the capacity to communicate across differences (tabligh, Socratic midwifery), and practical wisdom (fatana, Aristotelian phronesis). What each quality looks like in the texture of daily life.
Approach &	Detailed case studies of specific character moments from multiple

Methods	exemplars, personal reflection on which quality they most need to develop. Teacher shares how their own exemplars have formed them.
Teaching Principles	Make the exemplar human. The depth of the exemplars humanity, their fears, struggles, and perseverance, is what makes their character available for genuine imitation.
Formation Ground	Aristotle: The good person is the standard of virtue. Albert Banduras social learning theory confirms that observational learning from models is one of the most powerful mechanisms of character formation. The Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him), described in the Quran as an excellent model (uswah hasana, 33:21), is cited here as the supreme exemplar alongside Socrates, Marcus Aurelius, and other figures who exemplified philosophical virtue under pressure.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can describe three specific moments from an exemplary life that reveal their character and explain what each teaches about the quality they need to develop.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to see exemplary figures as formation models they can approach, not only admire from a distance.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from theoretical admiration of great character toward active deliberate imitation of specific qualities.

L07 Lesson 7: Justice Across Structures

What does genuine justice require at the level of social structures?

Why This Topic	Social ethics: the extension of justice from personal relationships to the structures and systems through which societies organize themselves.
Content	The concept of structural injustice: how social structures produce unjust outcomes without anyone individually intending them. The obligation that arises from awareness. The resources available for structural engagement.
Approach & Methods	Case study analysis, discussion of personal and collective responsibility. Teacher shares their own engagement with social justice.

Teaching Principles	From formation to action. Character education without social ethics is a private virtue project in a world that needs justice.
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Formation Ground	Iris Youngs concept of structural injustice, unjust outcomes produced by structural processes rather than individual intentions, is the most useful analytical tool here. John Rawls veil of ignorance test: a just arrangement is one that rational people would choose not knowing what position they would occupy within it. Peter Singers expanding circle of moral concern.
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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain structural injustice and identify one structural injustice they are willing to engage.
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Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to see their formation as inseparable from engagement with the worlds actual needs.
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Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from privately virtuous detachment toward public engaged commitment to justice.
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L08 Lesson 8: Love and Genuine Relationship

How does a tradition that takes love seriously think about attraction and commitment?

Why This Topic	The philosophical account of love as a graduated reality with a specific ordering, offered as a framework for integrating the relational desires that students are navigating.
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Content	Love as graduated: love of the ultimate good, love of those who embody that good, love of community, love of specific persons. The concept of ordering: each level of love is most healthy when ordered appropriately in relation to the others. Commitment as the form that genuine love takes across time.
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Approach & Methods	Honest class discussion on what students are actually navigating, philosophical perspectives on love and commitment. Teacher engages with both honesty and genuine wisdom.
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Teaching Principles	Meet them where they are. Students navigating real attraction need a serious dignified framework, not condemnation or silence.
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Formation Ground	Platos Symposium presents multiple accounts of love culminating in the ascent from the beautiful particular to Beauty itself. Aristotles three kinds of friendship place genuine care for the others character as the highest. C.S. Lewis in The Four Loves distinguishes affection,
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	friendship, romantic love, and unconditional love. The Islamic concept of mahabbah as the engine of creation positions love as the most cosmologically significant reality.
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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can describe the graduated account of love and explain how romantic desire fits within a life oriented toward genuine goods.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to approach their relational desires with dignity and a coherent philosophical framework.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from either suppression or unguided expression of relational desire toward integration within a genuine philosophical account of love.

L09 Lesson 9: The Intellectual Virtues

What does it mean to think well as a matter of character?

Why This Topic	Intellectual virtue as a distinct character category: intellectual humility, intellectual courage, epistemic precision, intellectual honesty, and the love of truth as stable dispositions rather than merely cognitive skills.
Content	The difference between intellectual competence and intellectual virtue. How intellectual arrogance corrupts reasoning. The virtue of remaining in genuine uncertainty when genuine uncertainty is the honest position.
Approach & Methods	Discussion of intellectual virtue failures, personal intellectual virtue audit. Teacher models intellectual humility in real time by genuinely revising a position when presented with better evidence.
Teaching Principles	Intellectual virtue is character. The student who reasons well is not just smarter, they are better.
Formation Ground	Aristotle distinguished intellectual virtues from moral virtues: episteme, techne, phronesis, sophia, and nous as the excellences of the rational faculty. Jonathan Haidts research on motivated reasoning: people systematically reason to conclusions they want to reach. Intellectual virtue is the capacity to resist this tendency.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can define five intellectual virtues and identify their own
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	greatest strength and greatest weakness in this area.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to examine their intellectual character rather than just their intellectual competence.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from purely skill-based intellectual development toward the cultivation of genuine intellectual virtue.

L10 Lesson 10: Suffering and Trust

Can I trust reality after what I have seen?

Why This Topic	The question of trust in the face of genuine suffering that cannot be explained, addressed philosophically and existentially. The move from theodicy through argument to relationship as the mature response.
Content	The limits of philosophical theodicy: no argument adequately justifies horrendous evil. The move the greatest traditions make: from the demand for explanation to the invitation to relationship. Trust as a form of knowledge not available without genuine encounter with the ultimate ground of reality.
Approach & Methods	Extended Socratic discussion, readings from the wisdom traditions on trust in suffering. Teacher shares their own experience of inexplicable suffering.
Teaching Principles	Move from argument to relationship. The student who needs an argument to trust reality has a transactional relationship with existence.
Formation Ground	Marilyn McCord Adams argues that horrendous evils require a personal God who suffers alongside the victim for those evils to be genuinely defeated. Simone Weil described the darkest suffering as the place where genuine love is most acutely tested. The concept of husn al-zann bi Allah in the Islamic tradition, holding a good opinion of ultimate reality, is cited as one tradition's answer to the question of trust.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain why philosophical theodicy is ultimately insufficient and describe the kind of trust that holds through genuine inexplicable suffering.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to move from demanding

	explanation toward a mature relational trust.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from demanding explanation toward a trust that holds through what cannot be explained.

GRADE 11 — Age 16-17

Metaphysics, Verified Knowledge, and the Integration of All Knowing

Grade 11 is the most philosophically demanding year. The full philosophical anthropocosmic vision is developed. Hikmah, the Islamic wisdom tradition's synthesis of philosophy, gnosis, and revelation, is introduced as the highest aspiration of human knowing. Verified personal knowledge as opposed to inherited belief becomes the explicit formation goal. The major intellectual objections are engaged with genuine depth and courage.

L01 Lesson 1: Formation as a Lifelong Journey

Have I been doing the inner work all along without fully knowing it?

Why This Topic	The formal naming of the formation arc. Students are shown that twelve years of character education has been a systematic interior formation program and are invited to own it consciously.
Content	The three stages of the self's development: reactive, reflective, and integrated, as a developmental map. A retrospective of the formation arc from Kindergarten. Where am I, where am I going, and what does the journey require?
Approach & Methods	Extended retrospective reflection, identification of current developmental stage, construction of a personal formation plan. Teacher shares their own formation arc.
Teaching Principles	Name what has been happening. Students who realize that the curriculum has been a systematic formation program often experience a significant shift in how they relate to the work.
Formation Ground	The concept of the nafs mutmainna, the self at rest in its deepest nature, from the Quran (89:27-30), cited alongside Aristotles person of fully developed practical wisdom, the Stoic sage, and the Buddhist concept of the fully awakened being. All point at the same developmental endpoint: the person in whom the reactive self has been sufficiently formed that action flows from a stable integrated interior.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can describe the full formation arc and identify their current position on it with specific evidence.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to consciously own their formation work as a serious lifelong project.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from being a recipient of formation to becoming a deliberate self-directing agent of one's own formation.

L02 Lesson 2: The Human Being as Mirror of the Real

Is the self ultimately material or is there something more?

Why This Topic	The most philosophically ambitious account of the self's nature: the human being as the creature uniquely capable of reflecting the full range of reality's attributes, not as a religious claim but as a philosophical position.
Content	The concept of the insan al-kamil, the fully realized human being, in the Islamic philosophical tradition, cited alongside Aristotles account of the philosopher who actualizes the highest human capacity, the Stoic sage who manifests the logos, and the concept of the self as the microcosm of the macrocosm.
Approach & Methods	Reading of selected philosophical texts on the fully realized human being, class discussion. Teacher engages with both enthusiasm and philosophical precision.
Teaching Principles	Introduce within the framework of service and responsibility, not divinity. The fully realized human being is not the one who has transcended humanity but the one who has most fully actualized it in service of others.
Formation Ground	Leibnizs concept of the human being as a mirror of the universe, capable of reflecting the intelligible structure of the whole. The Stoic concept of the sage who manifests the logos in their actions. Ibn Arabis concept of the insan al-kamil as the comprehensive locus of divine self-disclosure, cited as a philosophical position among others.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain the concept of the fully realized human being from two philosophical traditions and describe how this changes their understanding of their own formation potential.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to see their formation not as self-improvement but as the actualization of their deepest human potential.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from limited formation aspirations toward the expansive horizon of the fully realized human life.

L03 Lesson 3: The Meaning Crisis

Why does modern life feel so empty to so many people?

Why This Topic	Existentialism engaged directly: Nietzsche's death of God, Sartre's radical freedom, Camus's absurdism, and their genuine insights alongside their genuine limits.
Content	The modern meaninglessness crisis: its origins in the disenchantment of the world, the death of teleology, and the rise of the immanent frame. The genuine insights of existentialism that inherited meaning cannot substitute for genuine engagement. The genuine limits: the self cannot create meaning from nothing.
Approach & Methods	Philosophical reading and discussion, honest engagement with the pull of existentialist positions. Teacher engages with genuine intellectual respect.
Teaching Principles	Take Nietzsche seriously. The student who senses dismissal will find more truth in Nietzsche than in the curriculum. Genuine engagement is the only honest response.
Formation Ground	Nietzsche's death of God diagnoses the collapse of the transcendent framework that once gave life its meaning. Sartre follows: without God to define human essence, each person must create their own. Camus: the human demand for meaning meets a universe that offers none. Against these, Charles Taylor argues that the meaning-making resources of the great traditions remain available and are worth choosing.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can summarize the existentialist account of the meaning crisis and explain the curriculum's response through original nature and the philosophical account of the cosmos.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to engage existentialism honestly rather than defensively.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from defensiveness toward genuine grounded engagement with the most serious intellectual challenges.

L04 Lesson 4: Verified Knowledge

Is certainty an achievement a gift or both?

Why This Topic	The epistemology of certainty: the levels of knowing as both a description of intellectual maturation and a practical formation goal.
Content	Three levels of knowing revisited and deepened: propositional knowledge (knowing that), perceptual knowledge (knowing by direct encounter), and experiential or participatory knowledge (knowing by being). How genuine certainty is developed: through honest inquiry, sustained practice, and eventually direct encounter.
Approach & Methods	Personal certainty mapping, reading of Al-Ghazali's Deliverance from Error alongside Descartes' Meditations. Teacher shares their own journey toward genuine certainty about things that matter.
Teaching Principles	Certainty as a formation goal, not merely a cognitive state. The student who arrives at genuine participatory knowing about even one significant question has a reference point for the entire intellectual and spiritual life.
Formation Ground	Al-Ghazali's Deliverance from Error (c. 1100) is the most honest philosophical autobiography in the Islamic tradition: a radical doubt anticipating Descartes by 500 years that arrived at certainty deeper than argument through direct knowing. Descartes' Meditations (1641) pursued the same project and arrived at a more limited conclusion. William James documented genuine certainty arriving through direct experience in Varieties of Religious Experience (1902).

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can distinguish the three levels of knowing and describe where they are on that spectrum with respect to their core beliefs.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to desire genuine participatory knowing rather than settling for propositional knowledge.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from inherited description-level belief toward personally verified experience-level conviction.

L05 Lesson 5: The Best Objections to What We Believe

What are the strongest arguments against our deepest convictions and what are the honest responses?

Why This Topic	Genuine intellectual engagement with the strongest objections to the worldview the curriculum has been developing. Not defensive apologetics but honest philosophical inquiry.
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Content	The major objections: the problem of evil, the problem of divine hiddenness, the problem of religious diversity, the evolutionary debunking argument, and the problem of religious violence. Each presented in its strongest form before the most honest response is offered.
Approach & Methods	Structured intellectual debate with students presenting the strongest version of doubt and others presenting the most honest response. Teacher models intellectual courage and genuine uncertainty where warranted.
Teaching Principles	Strongest version of the objection first. The curriculum that presents a weak version of the opposing argument does not prepare students for real intellectual encounters.
Formation Ground	Alvin Plantinga's <i>Where the Conflict Really Lies</i> engages the evolutionary debunking argument and his <i>Free Will Defense</i> addresses the problem of evil. J.L. Schellenberg's <i>Divine Hiddenness</i> provides the most rigorous statement of the hiddenness problem. William Alston engages religious diversity. All are treated as serious philosophical positions deserving serious responses.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can present the strongest version of two major objections and provide the most intellectually honest philosophical response to each.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to feel equipped rather than threatened by intellectual challenges.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from faith defended through avoidance toward conviction stabilized through genuine intellectual engagement.

L06 Lesson 6: The Integration of All Knowing

Is it possible for all genuine knowledge to converge toward a single reality?

Why This Topic	The aspiration of hikmah, the Islamic wisdom tradition's synthesis, presented as the highest aspiration of human knowing: not the fragmentation of disciplines but their integration under a single organizing vision.
Content	The concept of a unified vision of knowledge: all genuine knowing, scientific, philosophical, experiential, and contemplative, as approaching the same reality from different angles. The concept of

	integration as the opposite of fragmentation.
Approach & Methods	Reading from the hikma tradition and from secular philosophers of integration, discussion of what integrated knowledge would look like. Teacher models the aspiration toward integration.
Teaching Principles	Integration, not syncretism. The aspiration is to recognize genuine truth wherever it appears, because all genuine truth belongs to the reality that is its source.
Formation Ground	Mulla Sadra's Transcendent Theosophy (17th c.) is the most ambitious synthesis in the Islamic tradition. Alfred North Whitehead's Process and Reality attempts a synthesis of science, philosophy, and religion. All three attempt what the curriculum's final year aspires toward: a genuinely integrated vision.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain the concept of integrated knowledge and describe how it differs from merely knowing many things.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to desire integrated knowledge rather than disciplinary fragmentation.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from isolated disciplinary knowledge toward the aspiration to integrate all genuine knowing under a single coherent vision.

L07 Lesson 7: Character Embodied in Leadership

What would it look like to lead from genuine character?

Why This Topic	Leadership formation: the great exemplars of character-based leadership studied as models, with the Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him) presented alongside Socrates, Marcus Aurelius, Lincoln, and others.
Content	The qualities of character-based leadership: consultation, genuine mercy, justice under pressure, willingness to be corrected, and honest self-knowledge. Leadership as the form one's formation takes when others are entrusted to one's care.
Approach & Methods	Leadership case analysis from multiple historical examples, personal leadership audit. Teacher shares their own leadership formation.

Teaching Principles	Leadership as the application of character. The formation arc points here: a person formed enough to serve others wisely and well.
Formation Ground	Aristotle's concept of the statesman who uses practical wisdom to serve the community's genuine flourishing. The Stoic concept of the emperor (Marcus Aurelius) who uses position to practice virtue rather than accumulate power. The Prophet Muhammad's model of shura (consultation) and rahma (mercy) cited as the exemplary case alongside others.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can construct a character-based leadership philosophy and apply it to one leadership situation they currently face.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to see leadership as the form their formation takes when others are entrusted to their care.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from leadership-as-power toward leadership as prophetically and philosophically modeled service.

L08 Lesson 8: Love as Cosmological Ground

What does it mean to say that love is the ground of all being?

Why This Topic	The concept of love, not as sentiment but as the metaphysical ground of reality, introduced as the deepest account of why there is something rather than nothing.
Content	The hidden treasure hadith: I was a hidden treasure and I loved to be known, so I created creation, cited alongside Leibniz's account of why anything exists, Plato's account of the Good as the source of all being, and Whitehead's account of God as the great companion who suffers alongside creation. Creation as an act of love seeking self-knowledge.
Approach & Methods	Reading of philosophical texts on love as metaphysical ground. Teacher shares how this concept has shaped their own life.
Teaching Principles	Love as the curriculum's deepest endpoint. The fully formed human being is the one who loves genuinely, who has the interior clarity and stability to love what is genuinely worth loving in the right order.
Formation Ground	Plato's account of the Good as beyond being, the source of all existence. The Christian concept of God as love (1 John 4:8). The Islamic hidden treasure hadith's account of creation as divine love

	seeking self-knowledge. Whitehead's process theology. All converge on the same insight: the ultimate ground of being is love.
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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain the concept of love as cosmological ground and describe how it changes their understanding of their own existence.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to experience their existence as an act of love rather than a brute fact.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from a dutiful relationship with reality toward a genuinely loving one.

L09 Lesson 9: Character and Culture

How does the Islamic way of life form character automatically?

Why This Topic	The Islamic practices analyzed as a deliberately designed counter-habitus using both the Islamic formation tradition and Bourdieu's sociological framework.
Content	How the Islamic daily practices reshape the dispositions of consumer culture: salah (five daily prayers) interrupts the flow of productivity and reorients attention; sawm (fasting) interrupts consumption; zakah (obligatory giving) interrupts accumulation; hajj (pilgrimage) interrupts privilege and status. The practices are formation interventions producing specific dispositions in those who inhabit them sincerely.
Approach & Methods	Cultural formation audit, analysis of Islamic practice as deliberate counter-habitus. Teacher maps their own habitus.
Teaching Principles	Culture before individual agency. The student who believes they are a pure autonomous agent is the most thoroughly formed by their culture without knowing it.
Formation Ground	Bourdieu's concept of habitus provides the sociological framework for understanding why the Islamic practices work as formation interventions: they are a counter-field generating counter-dispositions. The Confucian concept of ritual propriety as formation practice serves a similar function. The Stoic philosopher's daily practices of contemplation and voluntary discomfort are the Western equivalent.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain the Islamic practices as habitus formation and describe three specific dispositions that regular practice develops.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to experience their religious practices as formation tools rather than compliance requirements.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from compliance-based practice toward practices inhabited as a joyful intentional counter-formation.

L10 Lesson 10: The Dissolution of the False Self

What would it mean to release the ego before physical death?

Why This Topic	Fana, the dissolution of the ego-self, introduced as a psychological and philosophical concept: the death of the false self as the precondition for the fully alive life.
Content	The concept of the false self, the ego's program of self-protection and approval-seeking, as the primary obstacle to genuine living. The concept of its dissolution as the condition of full aliveness. The paradox: dying to self is the condition of genuine life.
Approach & Methods	Reading of philosophical and contemplative texts on ego-dissolution, personal reflection on where the false self is most active. Teacher shares their own experience of ego-release.
Teaching Principles	Do not rush this lesson. Students who are ready for it have been most honestly engaged with the earlier formation work.
Formation Ground	Iris Murdoch's concept of unselfing, the temporary suspension of the ego's concerns to see clearly. Donald Winnicott's distinction between the true self and the false self, the defensive structure that protects the true self at the cost of genuinely living. The Islamic concept of fana, dissolution of the nafs in the divine will. The Zen concept of anatta as the dissolution of the fixed ego-identity.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can explain ego-dissolution as the dissolution of the false self rather than physical death and identify one area where their false self is most active.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to desire the dissolution of the false self rather than fearing it.

Dispositional

Over time, this contributes to moving from ego-protection toward the willingness to release the false self in service of genuine life.

GRADE 12 — Age 17-18

Integration, Vocation, and the Return

Grade 12 is the integration and transmission year. The curriculum's great themes are brought together in a synthesis that is not academic but existential. The final lesson returns to where the curriculum began in Kindergarten: the question of who made the world. The student who asks it now has traveled the full arc.

L01 Lesson 1: Who Have I Become?

If I look honestly at myself now versus who I was at the beginning what has changed?

Why This Topic	The formation audit: a comprehensive honest self-assessment of character development across the full twelve-year arc.
Content	Using the full formation vocabulary of the curriculum as the framework for honest self-assessment: which stage of the self am I primarily in? What forms of misdirected devotion are most active in me? What do I genuinely know versus merely believe? Where is the gap between stated and lived values?
Approach & Methods	Extended honest self-accounting exercise, small-group sharing, personal letter to the Grade 1 self. Teacher shares their own formation audit with genuine vulnerability.
Teaching Principles	Honest before celebratory. A formation audit that is only positive is not honest.
Formation Ground	Marcus Aurelius' Meditations, a private self-accounting practice spanning decades, is the model for this exercise. The concept of honest self-accounting appears in the Islamic muhasaba tradition, the Stoic evening review, and the Jesuit examen. The quality of the self-accounting determines the quality of the formation that follows.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can write a comprehensive honest self-accounting using the full formation vocabulary, identifying genuine growth and ongoing struggles.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to see themselves clearly without either self-condemnation or self-congratulation.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from defensive or superficial self-assessment toward honest compassionate clear-eyed self-knowledge.

L02 Lesson 2: The Scholar-Practitioner

What does it mean to be someone whose knowledge has genuinely transformed them?

Why This Topic	The concept of the scholar-practitioner, the person in whom knowledge and being have become unified, as the identity horizon of the formation project.
Content	The classical distinction between knowing about something and knowing it in the full sense: knowing by being shaped by it. The scholar who knows about justice and the just person who knows justice from the inside. The formation goal: to be someone in whom knowledge has genuinely produced transformation.
Approach & Methods	Discussion of exemplars in whom knowledge and action were integrated. Teacher shares their own scholar-practitioner identity.
Teaching Principles	The identity offer, not the career option. This is about the deepest form of identity available to a person who has genuinely engaged the formation arc.
Formation Ground	Al-Ghazali's concept of the alim al-rabbani, the divinely-rooted scholar whose knowledge has formed them, cited alongside the Aristotelian concept of the person of practical wisdom whose knowledge of virtue is inseparable from virtuous action, and the Stoic concept of the sage whose philosophy is a way of life rather than a set of propositions.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can articulate the distinction between knowing about and genuinely knowing and describe one area where their knowledge has genuinely transformed them.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to desire the integration of knowing and being.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from knowledge-accumulation toward knowledge-transformation.

L03 Lesson 3: Vocation: The Specific Gift

What have I been given and what must I do with it?

Why This Topic	Vocation introduced not as career but as calling: the intersection of specific gifts, specific formation, and specific need.
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Content	What I have been uniquely given: specific gifts, formation, access, relationships, and circumstances. What the world uniquely needs from someone with precisely this combination. The convergence of gift and need as the beginning of vocation.
Approach & Methods	Vocational discernment exercises, discussion of vocation as an evolving understanding. Teacher shares their own vocational journey.
Teaching Principles	Specificity matters. A generic calling requires no formation. A specific vocation requires everything the curriculum has built.
Formation Ground	Frederick Buechner's definition: The place God calls you to is the place where your deep gladness and the world's deep hunger meet. Martin Buber's concept of the particular way, each person's unique path which cannot be walked by anyone else. The Islamic concept of amana as applied to individual gifts and capacities.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can identify their three strongest gifts, one world-need they are uniquely positioned to address, and articulate a provisional vocational calling.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to feel the weight and joy of having been given something specific to do with their specific life.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from vague aspiration toward specific responsible joyful vocational clarity.

L04 Lesson 4: The Good Life: Synthesis

How do all the pieces fit together into a life worth living?

Why This Topic	The synthesis lesson: all major themes brought into a single coherent vision of what a genuinely good human life looks like.
Content	The integration of original nature, the self's development, virtue, integrity, genuine knowing, relationships, vocation, justice, and love into a single life architecture. When all dimensions of a life are oriented toward the same center they reinforce each other.
Approach & Methods	Constructing their own architecture of a good life, peer sharing and feedback. Teacher shares the architecture of their own life.
Teaching	Coherence over completeness. The student who cannot connect the

Principles	parts has not yet integrated the curriculum.
Formation Ground	Aristotle's concept of eudaimonia as the integration of all dimensions of excellent human functioning: not happiness as momentary satisfaction but flourishing as the full actualization of one's capacities in genuine community. Susan Wolf's account of meaningful life as the convergence of subjective engagement and objective worth. The Islamic concept of saada (genuine flourishing) as extending across both this life and the next.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can construct a coherent architecture of the good life that integrates all major curriculum themes.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to feel the coherence of an integrated properly ordered life.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from living by default toward living from a coherent examined integrated life architecture.

L05 Lesson 5: Reality: A Unified Account

What is the relationship between who I am what the world is and what grounds it all?

Why This Topic	The full philosophical synthesis: the unified account of self, cosmos, and ultimate reality that the curriculum has been developing across twelve years.
Content	The unity of the account: the cosmos is not merely mechanism but a reality oriented toward its own source; the human being is the creature uniquely capable of consciously participating in that orientation; the formation of the self is the development of that participatory capacity; and all genuine knowledge approaches the same reality from different angles.
Approach & Methods	Philosophical discussion of the unified account. Personal synthesis exercise. Teacher shares their own integrated vision.
Teaching Principles	The master insight. Every lesson in the curriculum has been a different angle on the same reality.
Formation Ground	Alfred North Whitehead: The notion of God is that of an actual entity immanent in the actual world, but transcending any finite cosmic epoch, a tender care that nothing be lost. Charles Taylor: The highest aspirations of human beings are not merely projections of desire onto

	a neutral cosmos but responses to genuine goods constitutive of what we are. The concept of tawhid, the unity of God as simultaneously metaphysical, cosmological, psychological, and ethical, cited as the most elegant statement of the unified account.
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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can articulate the curriculum's unified philosophical vision and describe how it unifies all major themes.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to feel the unity of all their formation work in a single integrated account of reality.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from tawhid as a theological proposition toward tawhid as a lived embodied experienced reality.

L06 Lesson 6: The Threshold

What is this crossing point I am standing at?

Why This Topic	The transition from school as a genuine liminal threshold, a formation opportunity that most students pass through as mere administration.
Content	Arnold van Gennep's concept of the rite of passage: separation from prior identity, the liminal space of not-yet-knowing, and incorporation into new identity. The concept that thresholds are formation opportunities of the highest order and that the contemporary world has lost most genuine rites of passage.
Approach & Methods	Structured liminal reflection, ritual acknowledgment of the crossing. Teacher shares their own experience of formative thresholds.
Teaching Principles	Name the threshold. Students who experience this as merely administrative miss an extraordinary formation opportunity.
Formation Ground	Arnold van Gennep's <i>The Rites of Passage</i> (1909) demonstrated that every known human culture marks significant transitions with structured rituals. Victor Turner's analysis of liminality showed that genuine transition requires the experience of being between: no longer the old self, not yet the new. The curriculum deliberately recreates this liminal space here.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can describe the three phases of a genuine rite of passage and identify what they are separating from and arriving into.
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Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to inhabit the threshold consciously rather than passing through it unconsciously.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from experiencing life's thresholds as bureaucratic events toward inhabiting them as genuine formation opportunities.

L07 Lesson 7: My Manifesto

Who am I and what do I stand for?

Why This Topic	The public articulation of formed identity: a manifesto is a statement of who one is, what one has verified for oneself, what one values above all, and what one intends to do with one's formation.
Content	Writing a personal manifesto: who am I at my deepest? What do I know to be true because I have verified it in my own experience? What do I value above all? What will I not compromise? What am I for?
Approach & Methods	Personal manifesto writing (multiple drafts), small group sharing, optional public presentation. Teacher shares their own manifesto.
Teaching Principles	Public articulation completes formation. The student who can say who they are, not as performance but as genuine self-disclosure, has internalized the arc.
Formation Ground	The concept of shahada, the Islamic declaration of faith as a personal testimony, a bearing witness, is cited as the model for the personal manifesto: not a belief list but an act of testimony to what one genuinely knows to be true. The philosophical tradition of the personal confession (Augustine, Rousseau, Montaigne) as the most honest literary form.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can write a personal manifesto of at least 500 words integrating the major formation themes into a genuine statement of who they are.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to articulate their formed identity publicly for the first time.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from vague unarticulated selfhood toward a clearly stated publicly owned formation-grounded identity.

L08 Lesson 8: The Long Game

Am I in this for the long run?

Why This Topic	Formation as a lifelong project: the curriculum gives students a map for the journey they are beginning, not a destination they have arrived at.
Content	The concept that character formation never ends, that setbacks are features not failures, and that the formation horizon always extends further than any present achievement. The concept of the formation community: people who continue the work together.
Approach & Methods	Discussion of lifelong formation through exemplars, personal formation trajectory projection. Teacher shares their own ongoing formation.
Teaching Principles	End with the beginning. The final lesson of the curriculum should feel like the opening of a door, not the closing of one.
Formation Ground	Marcus Aurelius wrote his Meditations as an emperor late in life still working on the same formation questions he had as a young man. Montaigne wrote his Essays as an old man still genuinely unsure about most things that matter. The formation arc in the greatest figures of the tradition never reaches a terminus: it deepens. This is not discouraging. It is the most liberating thing the curriculum can say.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can describe their formation trajectory for the next five years and identify two practices they will maintain and two areas they will prioritize.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to feel genuinely excited about the formation work ahead rather than relieved it is over.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from experiencing formation as a school program toward embracing it as a lifelong project of becoming more fully human.

L09 Lesson 9: Sending Forward: What I Will Give

What will I pass on to those who come after me?

Why This Topic	Legacy and transmission: the formed person is not only the recipient of wisdom but its carrier. The curriculum's final question: what will you send forward?
Content	What they have received through twelve years of formation. What it means to carry that forward deliberately. The concept of the chain of transmission as a structure of responsibility. What they will specifically send forward.
Approach & Methods	Legacy letter to the next generation of students, reflection on their role in the transmission chain, ceremony of completion. Teacher shares what they hope they have transmitted.
Teaching Principles	End with responsibility, not achievement. Formation is not for the self alone.
Formation Ground	Edmund Burke: Society is indeed a contract between the dead, the living, and those yet to be born. The concept of silsila in the Islamic tradition, the chain of transmission through which formation has been carried from the Prophet (peace be upon him) through generations of teachers, is cited as the most explicit version of this understanding.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can write a legacy letter to incoming students and articulate one specific formation gift they intend to transmit.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to feel the honor and responsibility of being part of a transmission chain.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to moving from formation as a personal project toward formation as a communal transgenerational responsibility.

L10 Lesson 10: Who Made the World? Revisited

What is the relationship between the question I asked in Kindergarten and everything I now know?

Why This Topic	The curriculum returns to where it began. The student who asked who made the world in Kindergarten and the student who asks it now have traveled the full arc. The question is the same. The student is not.
Content	The full synthesis of what the curriculum has been pointing toward across twelve years: the cosmos is not merely mechanism but ongoing

	reality oriented toward its source; the human being is the creature uniquely capable of consciously participating in that orientation; and the student who has genuinely traveled this arc is now capable of asking this question from the inside.
Approach & Methods	Extended contemplative session, final honest self-accounting of the entire formation arc, readings from the great tradition. Teacher reads from their own formation archive.
Teaching Principles	Return to wonder at a higher level. The wonder of Kindergarten was immediate and unreflective. This wonder has passed through the nafs, through the intellect, through the stages of self-knowledge, and arrived somewhere deeper. This is the difference between inherited belief and verified knowledge.
Formation Ground	Leibniz's question why is there something rather than nothing returns here as the foundation of wonder rather than the entry point of argument. The hidden treasure hadith: I was a hidden treasure and I loved to be known, so I created creation, cited as the most beautiful answer alongside Whitehead's account of a tender care that nothing be lost. The student who has traveled the full arc is now capable of receiving this not merely as information but as recognition.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Conceptual	Students can articulate how the question who made the world has changed for them between Kindergarten and now and describe what the full arc has been pointing toward.
Reflective	This lesson creates conditions for students to experience the full arc of their formation as a single coherent journey toward genuine self-knowledge and genuine knowing of the Real.
Dispositional	Over time, this contributes to the deepest formation outcome available: a human being who sees the world as oriented toward something genuinely real, who knows themselves as a participant in that orientation, and who lives accordingly.

ASSESSMENT APPENDIX

The Central Principle

You cannot assess the interior life without corrupting it. The student whose integrity is being graded will perform integrity. Every assessment instrument is designed around one question: does this assess genuine interior formation, or does it assess the performance of formation? Instruments that produce the latter are excluded regardless of institutional convenience.

Five-Level Assessment Architecture

Level 1 — Lesson Exit	Three questions at lesson end: (1) Central concept in your own words. (2) One example — from story, history, or your life — where you saw this. (3) One question this lesson left you with. Never graded on personal content — only on genuine conceptual engagement.
Level 2 — Reflective Portfolio	Termly reflective journal assessed on quality of honest engagement (not content of disclosure) on a 4-point scale: Deep / Engaged / Surface / Absent. Private option is structurally non-negotiable.
Level 3 — Annual Narrative	A testimony written to the student by their formation teacher. Not a grade. Documents observable engagement, intellectual development, moments of courage or honest self-examination. Never addresses interior spiritual state. Not shared with parents after Grade 6 without student consent.
Level 4 — Threshold Conversations	One-on-one formation conversations at end of Grades 5, 8, 11, and Grade 12 capstone. Not evaluative — witnessing encounters designed to support genuine identity transition at the liminal threshold.
Level 5 — Grade 12 Capstone	Formation Portfolio (curated selection with reflective commentary) + Personal Manifesto + optional Public Presentation. Assessed on three dimensions: Integration, Honest Engagement, Formation Vocabulary Depth.

What Is Never Assessed

The content of personal disclosures · The student's religious practice or belief · Spiritual stage or interior condition · Sincerity of conviction · Any submission marked with the private option

Arête: A K-12 Character Formation Program · Complete Scope & Sequence